

All Wars Since 1990 Have One Thing in Common - And It's the Same Thing Fueling the Global Conflict of Tomorrow



- Part I: A history of Ukraine before the war, and how its incredibly Byzantine politics accidentally sucked in its paranoid neighbor.
- Part II: A history of Russia's war on Ukraine from 2014 to the escalation in 2022, and how it ended up sparking a new Cold War.
- Part III: A survey of all the popular theories of why Russia invaded Ukraine and why they're wrong, and a history of American foreign policy in Eastern Europe, especially NATO expansion.
- Part IV: The incredibly stupid and insane story of a fringe political sect and how it connects to both the war and a lot of other terrible things that have happened in the last 10 years.

Part I: How Ukraine's Fake Culture War Became a Real Geopolitical Conflict

Until the bombs started dropping, no one thought Ukraine was worth understanding.

The past 10 years of Ukrainian history have been the site of some of the worst journalistic malpractice of the 21st century—on par with the run-up to the Iraq War. And now, like in Iraq, tens of thousands of people are dying. And now that everyone is paying attention, they're doing so from a place of zero context.

Because many popular misconceptions about this topic are better well 'known' than the truth, this article will rely on primary sources and corroboration as much as possible. Both can be found as footnotes and as links denoted by the number here.

And so it's not surprising that even the people who should have known better got so much completely wrong. And so the first question I'd like to ask is: why? Why did everyone assume—most importantly the Russians—that Ukraine was just too divided to fight back?

This is a rather long article about the events that have transpired, and you'll want to stick with me—because this is going to go to some crazy places. But I promise I'm going to show you sides of the story that no one else has showed you.

So we start in 2000, with the typical post-communist story:

Freedom, misplaced optimism, privatizations, economic crisis, oligarchs, IMF structural adjustment programs, unsteady recovery—and a strongman. And in the early 2000s, Ukraine's strongman, [Leonid Kuchma](#) (President 1994–2004), was having a bad time with the Verkhovna Rada (the Ukrainian parliament).

November 28, 2000. His bodyguard had just released a secret 500-hour recording^[1] of all of his office hours—a recording in which not only did he solicit bribes, threaten politicians, discuss strategies to rig elections, and authorize the sale of an illegal weapon to Saddam Hussein—he also asked his security minister to "take care of" a troublesome journalist, [Georgie Gongadze](#) (journalist and founder of *Ukrainskaya Pravda*).^[1-1]

An excerpt of recording:^[2]

Kuchma: Before I forget, there is this guy named Gongadze.

Kravchenko: I've heard his name before.

Kuchma: He is the worst possible bastard, Gongadze.

Kravchenko: We've already been tracking him. We've already been looking for him.

Kuchma: Well, the Chechens should kidnap him and take him to Chechnya.

Kravchenko: And demand a ransom.

Kuchma: They should strip him and leave him naked.

Which is a very bad thing to be heard saying about a journalist three months before his decapitated corpse is discovered in the woods.

People were fed up. But even more dangerously, two of Kuchma's subordinates had become decidedly more popular than him. [Viktor Yushchenko](#) (Prime Minister 1999–2001) was a neoliberal economist who had run the central bank in the 90s and developed a reputation for being unusually honest. When Kuchma found his government insolvent and completely cut off by both the IMF and the private sector, he put Yushchenko in charge of finding money. Yushchenko, in turn, put a woman named [Yulia Tymoshenko](#) (Deputy Minister 1999–2000) in charge of finding it in the energy sector.

Yulia Tymoshenko had been the oligarch with a near-monopoly on importing natural gas from Russia. But when the political winds changed, she was pushed out, investigated multiple times, and lost most of her money. So she reinvented herself as an anti-oligarch oligarch—the politician who could make the other energy oligarchs pay because she knew the ropes.^[3] She managed to close four billion dollars a year's worth of loopholes by which energy oligarchs were milking the government dry. And Yushchenko took the money and used it to pay down money owed to pensioners.

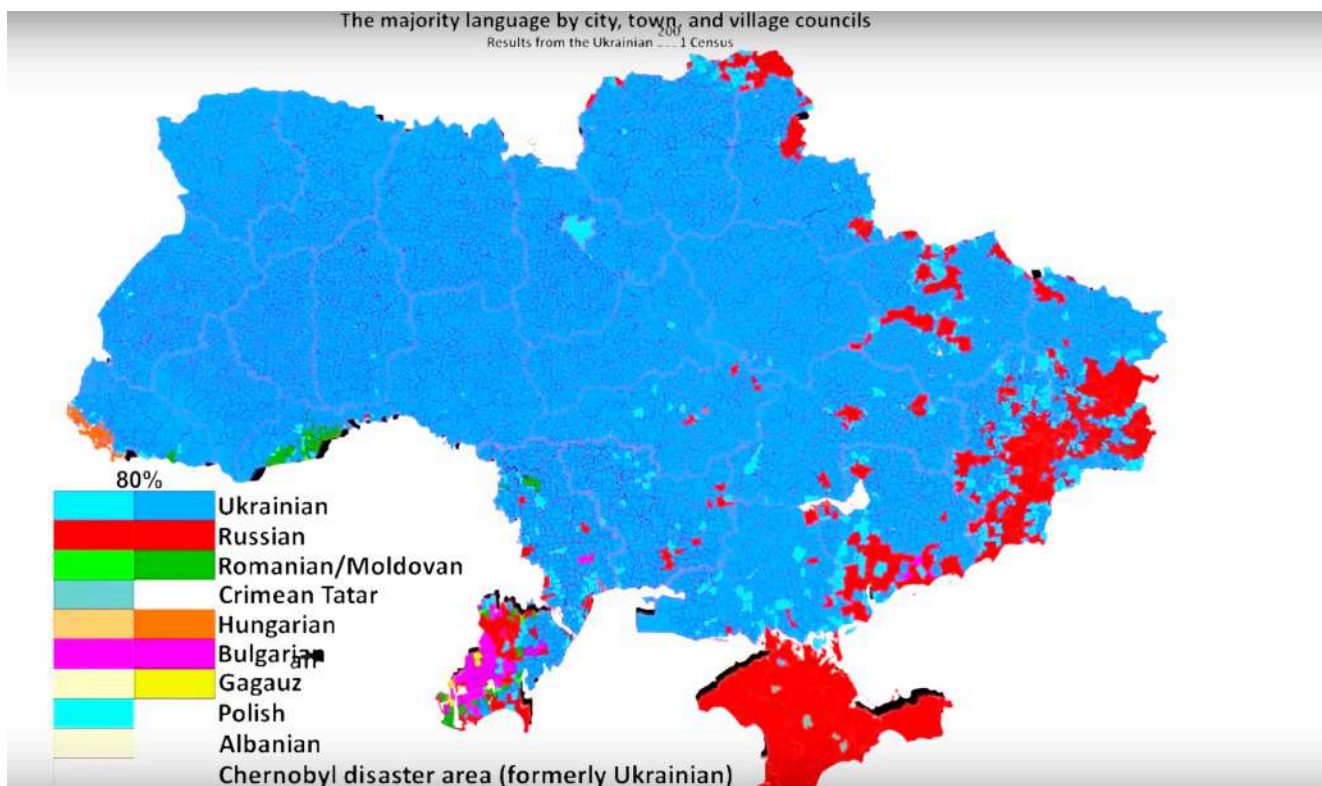
In a country mired in enough corruption, a tight-fisted conservative neoliberal can become a populist hero. Blunting Yushchenko's anti-corruption message by spreading rumors that he was going to split the country and possibly ban the Russian language—or even ban the Russian Orthodox Church^[4]

If Kuchma was going to win his next election, he was going to need to get rid of the two of them without generating a backlash. So first he tried to split them up by forcing Yushchenko to fire Tymoshenko. And when that didn't work, he just fired Yushchenko. But Yushchenko immediately formed an opposition party, which immediately went to the top of the polls. And when that didn't work, Kuchma realized he was not going to win re-election, so he decided to pick a successor that could run against Yushchenko. That candidate ended up being his current Prime Minister, [Viktor Yanukovych](#). But Viktor Yanukovych was a former street tough with no real campaigning skills and zero charisma. So instead of trying to win on charm, he turned the race into a linguistic culture war, stating to Yushchenko that:

"Nobody will be closing any Russian language schools. Third, nobody will be dividing Ukraine into three sorts of Ukrainians, as was suggested on placards and posters in Kyiv and most of Ukraine"

which were put up, by the way, by pro-government forces, he continued:

"Crimea will always belong to Crimeans and Ukraine. Nobody will be surrounding Luhansk and Donetsk with barbed wire. You're a serious person—don't repeat these myths. Unity of Ukraine—let's consider it a holy temple which every politician should guard. And when he loses, he shouldn't run to a neighboring country. Let's play the card of separatism? Federalism? Let's create a Southern and Eastern republic?"



Now, you've probably heard some things about Ukraine being divided between Russians and Ukrainians—and that's partially true, but misleading. In reality, everyone in Ukraine speaks Russian, and about 70 percent of Ukrainians speak Ukrainian. So when people say "Russians" or "ethnic Russians" or "Russian speakers," they mean the segment of the population that can't speak Ukrainian.

The real divide in Ukraine is a three-way split:

- between ethnic Ukrainian nationalists in the far west,
- the professional middle class based in Kyiv who tended towards Russian because you needed it to advance in the Soviet bureaucracy,
- and the [Russophone](#) east of the country, which was previously the Soviet Union's industrial heartland and is now Ukraine's rust belt.

The first group tended towards Yulia Tymoshenko, the second towards Yushchenko, and the third group towards Victor Yanukovych. But since all three of them had come out of the same administration and were all pursuing basically the same economic and foreign policies, Yanukovych was going to need a deeper issue to act as a wedge between Yushchenko and the east of the country—and he found the United States.

In 2004, the US's global reputation was plummeting, and Yushchenko's wife was American. So the regime-controlled media portrayed Yushchenko as a puppet of America who wanted to tear Ukraine away from Russia and put it in NATO. This was a weird accusation, because it was Kuchma who had desperately wanted to get Ukraine into NATO—going so far as to send a thousand soldiers to Iraq as a bribe to George Bush. But Kuchma controlled TV, so it stuck. And it attracted Ukraine's anti-Russian far right to Yushchenko's cause.

This, in turn, made the east nervous—not so much because of any worry about ethnic violence, but more because Ukrainian nationalism feels like an attack on their cultural self-identity as the people who liberated Ukraine from Hitler, rather than the people who conquered Ukraine for Stalin. This is all to say that the divide in Ukraine is more like a US-style culture war than a Balkan-style ethnic struggle. For politicians and oligarchs, it's mostly just a tool for cynically juking voter turnout—a farce.^[5]

But the Kremlin wasn't in on the joke. Kuchma successfully convinced them to see Yushchenko as a threat, so Russia donated 300 million dollars to Yanukovych's campaign and sent him their best campaign professionals.^[6] And they started running as many ads as they could for Yanukovych. When that didn't seem to work, Russia got the Patriarch of the Orthodox Church to endorse Yanukovych. And finally, when it was clear that none of this was going to stop Yushchenko, they just tried to murder him.^[7]

Doctors confirmed that opposition candidate Victor Yushchenko was poisoned during the campaign. He claims to have been poisoned in September. His face almost overnight changed into that of a scarred, bloated man. While the pro-Russia government of Ukraine back then said he must have eaten some bad sushi.



And so, when even that didn't work, they just decided to rig the election.^[8] The country's election commission ignored reports of fraud, declaring Kremlin-backed Victor Yanukovich the winner.

The problem, of course, with all those failed attempts to bias the outcome was that they were so transparently desperate that everyone realized they were going to rig the election before they did it. So when there was a 10-point difference between the exit polls and the official returns, no one needed to sit around waiting for an investigation.

Thus, Yulia Tymoshenko voiced a call to protest on the square, resulting in hundreds of thousands of pro-democracy Ukrainians in the streets. Following days the protesters clashed with police—hundreds of thousands protesting the results of the election and calling for a new vote. Yushchenko too has called for a nationwide strike, warning the country is on the verge of civil war. Kuchma was now forced to choose between a [Tiananmen Square](#)-style crackdown or backing down. He backed down and cut a deal with Yushchenko to allow for a new, fair election. And so, Victor Yushchenko became the third president of Ukraine, and Yulia Tymoshenko was announced as his prime minister.

But this begs the question: Ukraine was run by oligarchs, and it continued to be run by oligarchs—was this really a revolution?

Yes and no. First, let's talk about what we mean when we say Ukraine is an oligarchy. When we say America is an oligarchy, we just mean there's too much income inequality (think of [Elon Musk](#)), and also we really need campaign finance reform (recollect [Citizens United v.](#)

[FEC](#)). And when we say Putin's Russia is an oligarchy, we mean Putin has a bunch of billionaires who have to act as his capos—or else.

But in Ukraine, oligarchy is literal. Everyone who gets rich gets into politics. The reason is called parliamentary privilege: if you have a seat in parliament, you can't be investigated and charged with a crime unless the rest of parliament agrees to strip you of your privilege. Even a legitimate businessman will need that privilege to avoid getting squeezed by a prosecutor with connections to an even bigger oligarch. So it's financial suicide not to run for office after making a lot of money—either by forming your own party or bribing a major party into giving you a slot on their candidate list. This practice is so widespread that by the early 2000s, oligarchs were buying spots on lists not for themselves, but as speculative investments.^[9]

But in Ukraine... there is no class solidarity among oligarchs, mainly because they represent different sectors of the economy and come from different parts of the country. For example, Viktor Medvedchuk is a lawyer and fixer based in Kyiv, and he is known as the father of Putin's goddaughter. Petro Poroshenko, also based in Kyiv, made his fortune in agribusiness and candy production; he was a key bankroller of the Orange Revolution and later became the sixth president of Ukraine. Rinat Akhmetov, based in Donetsk, is the richest man in Ukraine, with interests in coal, coke, and iron. Ihor Kolomoyskiyi, from Dnipropetrovsk, is involved in steel and banking, though his business activities have been associated with fraud; he later became a significant political patron. Finally, Viktor Pinchuk, Kuchma's son-in-law based in Kyiv, made his fortune in steel pipes and left politics to become a prominent figure in [Davos circles](#). These oligarchs often attack and snitch on one another in parliament, reflecting their competing interests and regional bases rather than any unified class identity.

The Orange Revolution was, on a surface level, just the victory of one clan of oligarchs over the other. But on another level, it was a revolution in the relationship between the oligarchs and the middle class. Because there's no solidarity among oligarchs, any oligarch could immediately ride to power by throwing in their lot with the middle class civil society groups. This means that in Ukrainian oligarchy, unlike in Russian oligarchy, civil society doesn't get to rule, but it does get to play kingmaker. That diversification of power trickled down to the media—news stations all had to compete instead of colluding.

There was just one problem: Yushchenko and Tymoshenko don't actually like each other. In fact, they hate each other and are terrible at working together. The enmity mostly seemed to be personal. Within two years, Yushchenko had fired her, and after new parliamentary elections made hiring anyone else impossible, he chose—over her—Viktor Yanukovych, a man who had previously just tried to murder him. Only to again get into a power struggle with Yanukovych, then fire him, then bring back Yulia after finding no better option, only to get fed up with her again and start trying to illegally call new early elections. On virtually every issue, the three of them ran into gridlock. When one switched positions on a law, the other would also switch just out of spite. That didn't change when the mortgage crisis of 2008 hit.^[10]

On top of that, Russia began choking off the flow of natural gas to Ukraine in the middle of winter. This forced Tymoshenko to negotiate a new natural gas deal at a much higher price.

That deal, in 2009, cratered her popularity, and Yushchenko began openly accusing her of being a traitor and a tool of Putin. By their last two years in government, Yulia Tymoshenko and Victor Yushchenko were just actively trying to sabotage one another. This set the perfect stage for Yanukovych to make a comeback.

Now that Ukraine had an American-style electoral system, Yanukovych dumped his Russian advisors and got American ones: Paul Manafort (Campaign Manager of Donald Trump, 2016) and Tad Devine (Campaign Manager of Bernie Sanders in 2016). They got to work selling him as the perfect candidate to get Ukraine into the EU, which was a core issue for Kiev's middle class.

See, for all the talk about pro-Western or pro-Russian politicians, all politicians have to both keep Russia happy and keep Ukraine on the path to European integration. Yanukovych (then president from 2010 to 2014) was no different.

Why do Ukrainians need the EU when every other country seems to want to flee it? Well, reason one is just empirical. Ukraine looks at a country like Poland, which in the early '90s was in the same place as Ukraine but is now three times richer. (e.g. GDP per capita of Poland in 1991: \$1,731 and in 2012: \$14,271; while Ukraine in 1991: \$1,570 and in 2012: \$3,105)

Reason two: the EU creates a critical check on the power of oligarchs and their corruption. Joining the EU transforms Ukraine's oligarchs from being big fish in a little pond to small fish in a big pond. If a Ukrainian billionaire bribes or threatens a Ukrainian official, they'll likely get what they want. But if that same billionaire tries the same thing on a European bureaucrat, the response would be something like: *"I'm sorry, who are you? Am I supposed to be scared? Uh, yeah, no. Come back when you've killed as many people as Deutsche Bank. Thanks."*

And reason three: even the oligarchs want to go to the EU because what they lose in power they gain in the ability to go legit and cash out for huge profits. So Yanukovych used the fact that he was seen as Russia's guy to pitch himself as the perfect leader to get Ukraine into the EU while not setting off Russia. After he won, Yanukovych got to appeasing the Russians. He signed a 30-year lease for the Russian naval base in Crimea, which would disqualify Ukraine from joining NATO for an entire generation. And just to drive the point home, the parliament passed a law forbidding the president from joining any new foreign alliances. These moves were divisive, but they passed. Yanukovych had another agenda: revenge.

Now, let's step back four years to when Yanukovych was prime minister. Mostly, it was impossible to privatize anything because the socialists held key veto points. He was, however, able to bribe the socialists into privatizing one government asset—a massive mansion, called Mezhyhirya Residence^[11] that had previously been the summer house for the leaders of the Communist Party.



Viktor Yanukovych had managed to sell this place off at a low price to a little-known investor named Viktor Yanukovych (the very same person). And when Yanukovych and Yulia ran against each other in the 2010 presidential election, she called him out for this and implicitly threatened to re-nationalize the mansion. So, when Yanukovych became president, he threw her in jail.

But that left the question of what crime to actually charge her with, since she had kept her nose clean since entering politics. So, Yanukovych used the unpopular gas deal she had negotiated with Russia, arguing that she had agreed to a bad deal on purpose as part of a secret bargain with Putin and had betrayed Ukraine. Victor Yushchenko, though he knew better, agreed to play along and testify against her.

To the EU, this seemed like major democratic backsliding, so they made releasing Yulia from jail one of the preconditions for EU membership. To get the EU off his back, Yanukovych funded a massive smear campaign against Yulia, both domestically and internationally.^[12]

His team shopped out stories to conservative media outlets in Israel, Europe, and the US, making her out to be an anti-Semite and a Putin stooge. You might remember this story because one of the political pundits that took part was Ben Shapiro. But again, the Kremlin wasn't in on the joke, and this media campaign smeared Putin as a side effect of its smearing of Yulia, which sent the Russians into a paranoid frenzy.^[13] A leaked document from the Kremlin showed that even before it all went down, they were already convinced that Yanukovych and most of his oligarchs had turned against Russia, and that it would only be a matter of time before there was a second Orange Revolution that would destroy relations between Ukraine and Russia for good. Yanukovych was oblivious to all this, so he went on trying to court Europe for a good deal, and it seemed like he was making progress right up

until 2013, when suddenly Russia decided to just start sanctioning Ukraine^{[13-1][14]} and said they were going to keep sanctioning Ukraine until it dropped out of the EU negotiations^[15].

Europe and America treated this as a bargaining war with fairly low stakes. Russia treated it as an existential crisis. Russia's main envoy to Ukraine, [Sergey Glazyev](#), even threatened that signing the Association Agreement would nullify Ukraine's statehood and would lead to a Russian military intervention. Yanukovych thinks, *okay, so this is clearly a misunderstanding since I solved the whole NATO problem; I just need to reassure Putin*. So Yanukovych and Putin have a meeting. We don't know what happened in this meeting. What we do know is that immediately after, Yanukovych came to the EU negotiators and said he would need a huge amount of money from the IMF, something on the order of 50 billion dollars, in order to offset something to do with Russia^[15-1]. Because Europe and the IMF didn't know just how strong the threats had been behind closed doors, they assumed this was a cynical cash grab.

And the EU was already inclined to see Ukraine as more of a burden than an opportunity, so they didn't bite. Yanukovych walked away from Europe with nothing. President Viktor Yanukovych has said he's only suspending, not cancelling, Ukraine's planned deal on closer ties with the EU and still intends to sign an agreement at a later date.

In the interview, Yanukovych said:

"There's no change to our plans. We think we can sign once we get down to work and find solutions for economic problems."^[16]

But failure wasn't really an option for Yanukovych. He had won his election on a promise that he would get Ukraine into the EU, and now it looked like he had just been stringing everyone along. This resulted in: Thousands of anti-government demonstrators turned out again today, and some opposition leaders called for nationwide strikes after a night of bloody clashes between protesters and police. Hundreds of thousands of protesters have stormed the streets of the Ukrainian capital in recent days, upset that the country's president, Viktor Yanukovych, walked away from a deal with the European Union after warnings from Russia.

The thing you realize as you watch and read most of the journalism about [Euromaidan](#) is that it's almost impossible not to get swept away by the ultra-violent spectacle. Every report slowly bleeds into the same montage of blood-soaked scalps, burning tires, and candid snuff films. So instead, I'll try to focus on the politics.

Originally, support for the protests mostly came from sectors of the country that already hated Yanukovych, but the crackdowns were so excessive that they spread the backlash rather than crushing the movement. Soon, the leaders of the three biggest opposition parties had positioned themselves as the leaders of the movement. Those three men were: [Arseniy Yatsenyuk](#), a young technocrat who had taken the lead of Yulia Tymoshenko's party while she was in prison; [Vitali Klitschko](#), the former heavyweight champion who ended up inheriting what was left of Yushchenko's base after he left the presidency; and [Oleh](#)

[Tyahnybok](#), the slightly creepy leader of the crypto-Nazi [Svoboda party](#), who had found unprecedented success in the last round of parliamentary elections by moderating his image and by selling himself as a protest vote^[17].

And maybe because of all the money and free publicity he was getting from Yanukovych's party—in the hopes that Yanukovych could run against him instead of a more formidable opponent—as the movement got bigger and more institutionalized, Yanukovych got scared.

Protests spread to Yanukovych's part of the country in the south and the east. With his political base ready to disown him, Yanukovych had no choice but to start negotiating. Russia took this as a sign that they were right about Yanukovych—that he was going to betray them—especially when they found out the American embassy (with Victoria Nuland, Assistant Secretary of State for European and Eurasian Affairs—remember her, as she'll be important later) was arbitrating the negotiations^{[18][19]}. So he went a step further and tried to pass an anti-protest bill so vague it could plausibly criminalize just about anything, and that scared everyone in Ukraine.

So they put more pressure on him to break off negotiations and instead end the protest with overwhelming force. Yanukovych was trapped between a rock and a hard place, and his own party and security services were divided between hardliners and democrats^[20]. Shortly after, the shooting started^[21].

Reportage from CNN:

"The police are shooting directly at protesters. Here, a CNN photographer captures the moment when a group of medics is seen helping a man lying on the ground. There is a shot; one medic falls to the ground and tries to crawl away. We don't know if he survived. The death toll is still being counted, but in our hotel—which became a makeshift hospital run by volunteer doctors—13 bodies were brought into reception."

Yanukovych, like Kuchma before him, realized he was either going to have to sign a deal or spark a civil war. So, negotiations started to form a new unity government. Yanukovych would stay president; the leadership troika of the protests would get jobs as prime minister and his deputies, and they would all act as caretakers until the next election later that year. Flanked by European foreign ministers, Eastern-looking Yanukovych signed the deal. Note that the Russian envoy refused to witness it, so the deal stands, but there's no certainty it will last. In a moment that wasn't supposed to be caught on camera, the Polish foreign minister warned the opposition: "Sign it or else."

And then, just before Yanukovych was about to implement that deal—the deal that would have saved Ukraine from chaos—he suddenly got cold feet and disappeared from Ukraine.

"Can I very quickly just ask you: do you know where Victor Yanukovych is right now?" "It's a good question millions of Ukrainians want answered: Where is Yanukovych?" Responded Vitali Klitschko when asked about the whereabouts of President not giving any answer, and we cannot forget, that Vitali Klitschko was like his second in command.

Western media spun this as a story of people power scaring away a big bad dictator, but the truth was much more sinister. While the crowd was angry about the shootings, it shouldn't have been impossible to pacify them once the deal was signed and the Maidan triumvirate was on Yanukovych's side. However, one of the annexes of the agreement was that there would be an investigation into who shot whom on the 20th. The leaders of Yanukovych's security forces either thought, or were convinced by someone, that Yanukovych was getting ready to throw them under the bus. So, they decided to betray him first. Someone in the chain of command between Yanukovych and the riot cops ordered the cops to withdraw from all government buildings, and they, along with their boss, just disappeared. They would reappear a few weeks later, either in Russia or in Crimea, which was already in the process of being invaded by Russia. There was now no one standing between Yanukovych and the angry protesters except the far-right militias who were acting as Maidan security forces. This meant Yanukovych would have to renegotiate his resignation with absolutely zero leverage—or, you know, he could sneak out with as much of his expensive stuff as he could stuff into a helicopter (which he did) [22].

But for now, all Ukrainians knew was that their president had ghosted, and they needed to move fast to prevent the state from collapsing. Even Yanukovych's own party threw up their hands in frustration, voting to kick him out of office and install a provisional government. Yanukovych resurfaced in Russia, claiming the vote to remove him was unconstitutional and that he was still the legitimate president—which was probably true. But there's a remedy for that: come back and challenge it in court. He was literally refusing to come back.

Whether because of some phantom assassination plot, genuine fear for his safety, or pressure from Russia, Yanukovych was now giving Moscow the pretext they wanted to follow through on their previous threats. But it's not like Russia had been waiting for his permission. Many of the country's news stations in the east, controlled by pro-Kremlin oligarchs, began running scare stories portraying the new government as full of Nazis who would make speaking Russian illegal. This fueled protests in the mostly Russian-speaking cities of the south and east.

Then, in a grim parody of the original Maidan, Russia organized numerous coups in the regional capitals of oblasts where Yanukovych had won, using these protests as cover. These new, fake "coup" governments quickly declared themselves independent republics [23] [24].

They only discovered the truth because of a leaked phone call involving Sergey Glazyev, directed by Konstantin Zatulin, discussing cash payments for the protesters. But it didn't work—turns out you can't actually sustain a revolution with just 200 paid thugs. That is, except in Crimea, where they had real help [25][26]. Then, Russia used that as a pretext to ask Putin for a so-called "humanitarian intervention." At the time, most people believed these were spontaneous protests.

But in reality, Spetsnaz units without insignia had quietly landed just outside the city. They marched in, disarmed the local police, and effectively put the nearby military installation

under a light siege^[27]. What America was officially calling a Russian invasion of Ukraine, when Russian troops spread out throughout the strategic Crimean peninsula.

That moment marked a sharp escalation. After Crimea's annexation—where a rushed referendum replaced the original plan for moral autonomy, swiftly turning into a vote to join Russia and passing with an overwhelming 95% in favor despite only 60% of the population being ethnically Russian, so again it was clear to the public: it was rigged—the stakes in Ukraine's conflict moved from political bickering to a deadly existential crisis. What had been a divisive but mostly rhetorical culture war transformed into a brutal clash, with one side accusing the other of being bloodthirsty Nazis installed by the West, while the other saw their opponents as foreign-backed fifth columnists. The Ukrainian state was teetering on collapse, with real lives at risk, and Putin seemingly winning without firing a shot—crippling Ukraine's NATO ambitions, boosting his popularity, and humiliating Ukrainian nationalists.

Yet instead of stopping there, Putin escalated further. In January 2015, the Mariupol rocket attack struck, marking the beginning of a new, intense phase of conflict. The mystery remains: why risk so much after having seemingly gained all he wanted?

Part II: A history of Russia's war on Ukraine from 2014 to the escalation in 2022 in Donbas, and how it ended up sparking a new Cold War.



Part II covers Russia's first invasion of the country in 2014, and how despite not accomplishing much on the battlefield, Russia was able to convince the world through propaganda that Ukraine was simply having a civil war, and go mostly unpunished. A success that would lead Russia to launch more ambitious propaganda operations in the coming following years.

☞ "Guys like you are in what we call the 'reality-based community.' You believe that solutions emerge from your judicious study of discernible reality. That's not the way the world really works anymore: We're an empire now, and when we act, we create our own reality. And while you're studying that reality—judiciously, as you will—we'll act again, creating other new realities, which you can study too, and that's how things will sort out. We're history's actors... and you, all of you, will be left to just study what we do"

- by Anonymous Whitehouse Aide (allegedly Karl Rove) in 2004

Whitehouse reaction to the Mariupol rocket attack:

"So let me be clear on where things stand today: first, conflict is not inevitable. There is still time and space for diplomacy. The United States, in lockstep with our allies and partners, has offered Russia a path away from crisis and toward greater security.

Yeah, that vibe was really strange — instead of just doubting the war was coming because of solid reasons, there was this almost *petulant* attitude, like “How dare anyone suggest this is happening?” It felt less like healthy skepticism and more like a defensive, “I know better than you” stance.

What made it even odder was that the evidence was out there for everyone to see—satellite images, troop movements, open-source intelligence. You didn’t have to take anyone’s word for it; you could literally check the pictures yourself and say, “Yep, that military build-up is real.” Yet, some commentators just *refused* to acknowledge it, almost like it threatened their worldview or narrative. It was a weird mix of smugness and denial that made the skepticism feel less genuine and more performative. ^[28]

Right! It’s like seeing the entire staging of an invasion laid out in broad daylight and then acting like someone just pulled a prank. Almost like, “Nah, no big deal, those tanks are just

there for a parade or something.” It was clear, that the cognitive dissonance was wild.

And the tone—half mockery, half indignation—made it seem like acknowledging the obvious was somehow admitting defeat or feeding into fear-mongering. But this wasn’t some secret; it was an open book, *loudly* telling the world what was coming. Yet some people just *couldn’t* accept it without making it a contest of who’s more skeptical or tougher-minded. It was bizarre to watch, especially when we consider what the media were broadcasting back then.

This is not detached skepticism; this is an emotional investment in defending a much larger worldview. Sometimes you see people blaming this on the far left, or “tankies,” quote unquote, while sometimes you see people saying this is a matter of horseshoe theory—blaming the far left and the far right.

But look at who is actually peddling this story. One of the big pushes of Russian propaganda was [The Nation](#) magazine, which has never been particularly radical. Or [Matt Taibbi](#), who is a centrist left liberal. Or [Peter Hitchens](#), who is center-right. I don’t think *The Guardian* (author [John Pilger](#)) is anyone’s idea of revolutionaries, and [Glenn Greenwald](#) is whatever Glenn Greenwald is. This is a pan-ideological phenomenon, and it’s a relatively recent one — you didn’t see this even as late as 2012. It all started in 2014 with Russia’s decision to invade the southeast of Ukraine, also known as the Donbass, while protests persisted in Crimea on March 8th, 2014, as *Vice News* reported. ^[29]



After Crimea, the political divide in Ukraine started to shift from a linguistic or regional divide into a generation gap among Russian speakers. Young people were getting their news about the Maidan from their friends or the internet, whereas older people were getting it from Russian-language cable news. According to Russian cable news, Maidan was the start of a neo-Nazi, anti-Russian genocide. In reality, the new government was mostly made up of members from Yulia Tymoshenko's party, with Yulia's longtime second-in-command Oleksandr Turchynov (interim president from January 25th, 2014 – June 7th, 2014) as president, and the young technocrat Arseniy Yatsenyuk (prime minister from January 27th, 2014 – April 14th, 2016).^[30]

But it didn't really matter how innocuous the new regime was, since they were still appointed rather than elected in the aftermath of a dubious impeachment process. So, their promises to address Russian speakers' concerns mostly fell on deaf ears.^[31]

This was in part because, increasingly, Russia was aiding the anti-government protests by paying people to show up and bringing people in from across the border. So, the former Maidan protesters—scared that the protest might be a front for a new Russian invasion—became counter-protesters. Instead of bringing a new dawn, the Revolution of Dignity at first just brought more street fights, this time with police on the sidelines, while liberals and ultra-nationalists fought paid thugs and pensioner cable news junkies. They were fighting not over any actual policy but rather over completely hypothetical ones, and the Western media was generally happy to repeat Russia's story about this being a spontaneous, natural ethnic conflict inside Ukraine.^[31-1]

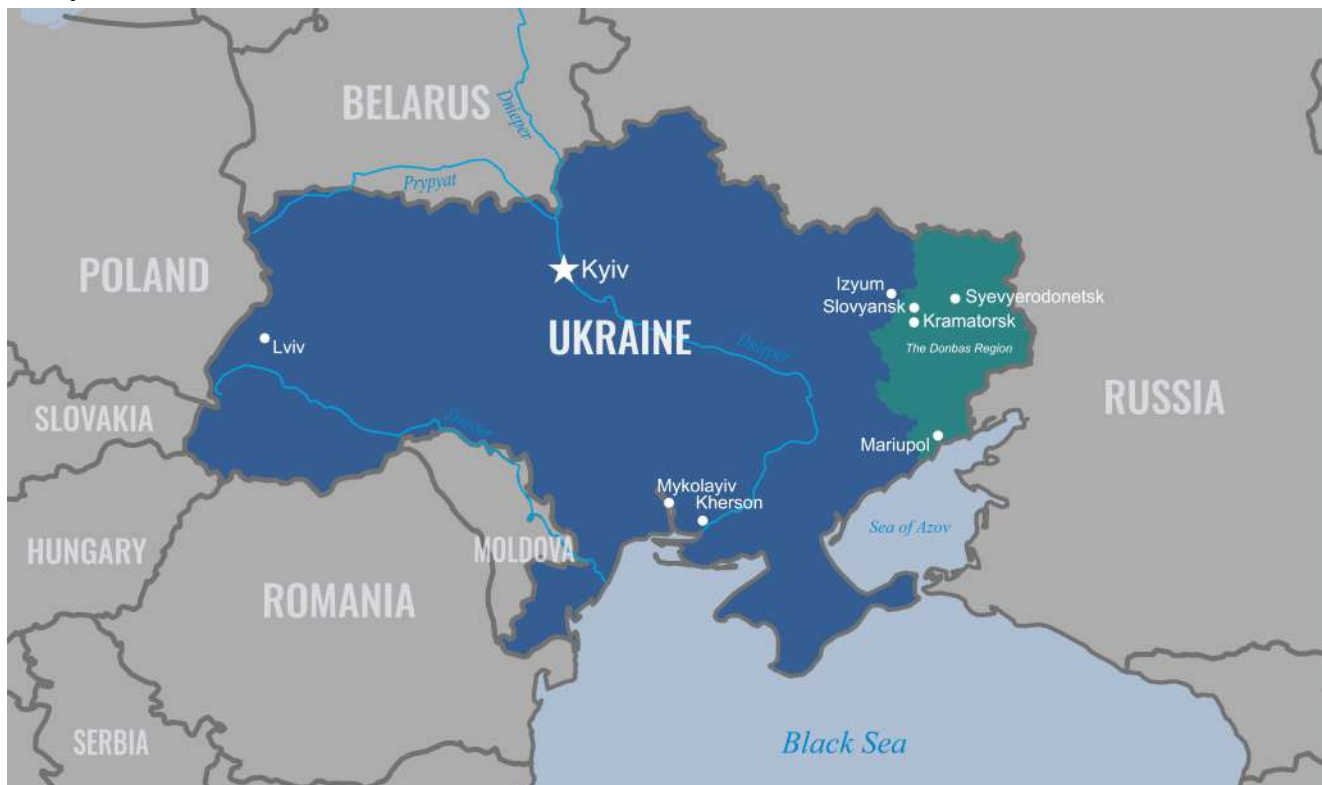
Namely because that's how it worked in the Balkans, and that was the last time the Western media paid any serious attention to Eastern Europe. Why change paradigms now? In other words, mainland Ukraine looked like a juicy target, but this was not enough to spiral into a civil war. So, Russia realized Ukraine was going to need another push, and for the purposes of plausible deniability, they would have to outsource it to a quasi-state actor. So, a plan was hatched: Russia organized what was once known in 19th-century America as a [filibuster \(military\)](#). Picking volunteers from the Crimean invasion force who were willing to sneak into Donetsk without any government-permit visa. But what kind of person would volunteer to lead this kind of unit? The answer: [Igor "Strelkov" Girkin](#) (FSB colonel and Defense Minister of the Donetsk People's Republic).^[32]

He was a colonel who had volunteered in Transnistria, fought with the Bosnian Serbs, did wet work in both Chechen wars, and fought in the invasion of Georgia. A big supporter of the movement to reinstate the Tsar and turn Russia back into an absolute monarchy that would rule over all the territory of the former Soviet Union, he got a job as a security official for the billionaire funder [Konstantin Malofeev](#), former investment banker turned far-right impresario^[32-1] — basically, the Russian [Peter Thiel](#) of U.S. in 2025 — of the Russian monarchist movement. It was that billionaire who helped finance his mission to take over Ukraine. Girkin is also an avid war memorabilia collector and historical re-enactor for the Russian Civil War, on the White side, of course. Much of what we know about the 2014

invasion of Ukraine comes from his decision to live-vlog it on a web forum for enthusiasts of military antiques.

The plan he hatched was elegant, if not exactly simple^[32-2]: the trained special forces would launch a pre-dawn raid on important targets in the cities of the Donbas. They would shoot it out with whoever was guarding the building, either kick out the defenders or hold them hostage, and then invite local compradors who would pretend that they had taken over the building all by themselves—just in time for the journalists to show up a few hours later in the morning. After a few days of chaos caused by the takeovers, during which everyone in eastern Ukraine would go over to Russia's side, it was assumed Russia could then send in its army and bloodlessly annex the south and east.^[32-3]

Other, less organized local groups also captured individual buildings in the big cities like Donetsk and Mariupol, but since they weren't well-armed, they were mostly just ignored and life continued as normal while everyone waited for some kind of negotiated solution. Girkin, on the other hand, had captured an entire town—a more remote town in the west called Slovyansk.



This wouldn't be an important distinction if Russia had just invaded, but instead the Russian army just massed at the border and waited and waited. The Ukrainian army waited too, both because they were barely functioning and because they were worried a crackdown would provoke a Russian invasion.

This created a problem for Slovyansk because the town was now under the control of a company of men with no authorization, no experience in governance, no preparation, and no real organization. In other words, Slovyansk had been put under martial law by a military with no chain of command—or, if you prefer: total chaos.

Chapter 1: Chaos (april 12th - July 11th, 2014)

One of the first things Girkin did was put in place a people's mayor. They appointed their own mayor, [Vyacheslav Ponomarev](#), a former soldier in the Soviet army. The town's elected mayor hasn't been seen in public since Friday. The real mayor had been locked in a basement. The first order of the people's mayor was the pogrom against the local Roma population^[33]. Then he put out a warning, telling people to report any suspicious activity — activity like speaking Ukrainian. People started disappearing at checkpoints, including journalists and international observers. Some, like the journalist, eventually got released; others, like an opposition city councillor, were discovered in the local river, disemboweled and bearing signs of torture like [Volodymyr Rybak](#), Horlivka City Councillor on April 20th^[34].

This outraged Western Ukraine, but no one in the occupied cities heard about it. The first thing the Russians did in every place they took over was to go after the TV antennas, and so a sort of photon curtain fell between the East and the West — each side living in different realities created by different television diets. So when Ukraine sent in troops, people on the Ukrainian side saw the Russians as having escalated first, and people in the occupied territory saw the Ukrainians as escalating first. That difference in perception would become increasingly important^[34-1].

The Russian incursion in the East didn't interrupt the street fighting in Western Ukraine, and in Odessa these clashes escalated to a gun battle that killed six pro-Ukraine protesters. The pro-Ukraine side retaliated by marching to the pro-Russian camp to burn it down. The pro-Russian side barricaded themselves into the building next door, and the two groups began shooting and throwing Molotov cocktails at each other. The resulting fire killed 42 people.

The fire had been a genuine freak accident. A small fire on the front door barricade spread to the main hallway, where unbeknownst to almost everyone there was a generator with a full fuel tank. When that tank caught fire, it formed a massive fireball that instantly killed the 40 or so people on the stairs above. But no one knew any of that at the time, so the Russian media had a field day.^[35]

The text below is from a broadcast on Russia Today. (**Important note: this entire report is fabricated by Russian propaganda — none of it actually happened.**) Despite that, they still aired the following blatant lies on RT:

"Women and children hid in the trade union's building. First, the armed men set fire to tents, then started throwing Molotov cocktails and grenades at the building. We heard shots fired and saw thick smoke. There were about 50 of us on the roof — men and women. The Right Sector was blocking the streets. We looked down at what was happening around us and thought they wouldn't let us out alive."

"People from other floors were brought down, and the extremists attacked them like a pack of wolves. At the same time, there were shots from behind the backs of the security forces. Someone was firing a machine gun. We have the empty shells to prove it."

"It's all about resources. The oligarchs are behind the scenes, and the fascists are on the front line, and they're just trying to destabilize and take over resources. You know who's behind this? It's the Mossad, the CIA, and the British MI6. Let's not kid ourselves, you know."

So, while in western Ukraine the shock of the fire calmed things down, as everyone took it as a sign they needed to de-escalate, in the east the fire was used to convince a large sector of the population that the conflict was existential. Ukraine turned its attention to the coming presidential election on May 25th, and the separatists began a massive recruitment drive — and not just locals. The neo-Nazi party Russian National Unity formed a legion^[36], the National Bolshevik Party formed a militia, a Chechen militia called the [Vostok Battalion](#) was sent, and even people from the west, sucked in by Russian media, joined in. Left-wing Spaniards joined and formed an anti-fascist battalion, where they fought side by side with American and Swedish neo-Nazis, people calling themselves the [Don Cossacks](#), and people calling themselves the Russian Orthodox Army^[37].

And an Orthodox Christian Stalinist biker gang called the Night Wolves^[38] all joined the fight. In May, Ukraine elected a new president, [Petro Poroshenko](#). Now with more legitimacy, the Ukrainian government felt confident enough to try and take back the east by force, but since the separatists had an unlimited supply of "Captured"^[39] anti-tank missiles and "captured"^[39-1] anti-air missiles—the battle would be slow and heavy on artillery, and fought mostly by volunteers with a few weeks, if any, military training; volunteers that would later consequently include neo-Nazis. But Ukraine had air power, and while the separatists were occasionally refreshed with more volunteers from Russia, the wave of local volunteers swept up by pro-Russia sentiment never materialized. Girkin couldn't hold on to Sloviansk, and so he delivered an ultimatum to the Kremlin: send help—real help, as in an army—where everything would fail. But Moscow was silent, so Girkin took his troops and left, and as he himself said:

"The siege of Sloviansk wasn't complete, and there was a chance to retreat using country roads. The thing is that these roads were under fire from artillery. {...} The exact number of victims we lost on the way out of Sloviansk is being calculated right now. Now there's a risk that they will siege and storm our Donest, which has one million residents. This is very sad."

The fall of Sloviansk marked the end of the honeymoon for the Russians for multiple reasons. Most important was the glimpse it provided of life under Russian occupation. When Girkin left Sloviansk, 40 or so people were still disappeared. The assumption was they were all just being held somewhere and would eventually be released—and most were, but not all.^{[29-1][40]}

To quote the reporter from Vice who was kidnapped also produced an episode about his experience, who was on-site^[29-2]:

"Right now, the authorities are digging up a mass grave site that the separatists used for their debt and possibly the dead — uh, of, uh, people that they had actually executed. But right now, they want to get the fresh remains out so that they can be identified and so that they can continue their investigation into what they believe was the execution of, uh, four protestants who lived in Sloviansk, were locals, and were killed potentially just so that their cars could be taken."

On top of that, the residents of Sloviansk who had rallied to the rebels in April were now rallying to the government. It turned out few people in the town actually cared about the Russian world or federalization but rather had just concluded early on that Russia would invade and wanted to be seen supporting the winning side first. On top of that, the whole propaganda line behind the rebellion was that if Ukraine recaptured territory^[40-1], there would be a massacre of Russian speakers. When those didn't materialize, the local population realized the fight maybe wasn't so existential.^[41]

Finally, Girkin's decision to withdraw from Slovyansk split the Russian ultranationalist movement in half. Girkin, sensing the Kremlin was going to betray him, used the opportunity to humiliate the Kremlin by posting that Russia didn't deliver on all the aid it had promised. One half of the ultranationalist movement believed him and blamed the Kremlin; the other half blamed Girkin for being too cowardly to make a last stand^[42]. This division culminated in an internet livestream argument between the ex-neo-Nazi self-proclaimed leader of the Donetsk People's Republic ([Pavel Gubarev](#), "People's governor" of the Donetsk People's Republic) and [Igor Bezler](#), the Russian special forces commander of the Gorlovka detachment, and one of the far-right neo-Soviet activists who had been bundling military aid ([Sergey Kurginyan](#), founder of the "Essence of Time" political party). In the course of this argument, they outlined what had been delivered, when, and whether it should have been enough to hold the town. ^[43]

And we should pause here because now would be a good time to note that Russia could still walk away here and leave with everything it could want, minus a little embarrassment. All they'd have to do is order their agents home and claim they had never been involved to begin with. Instead, they escalated again.

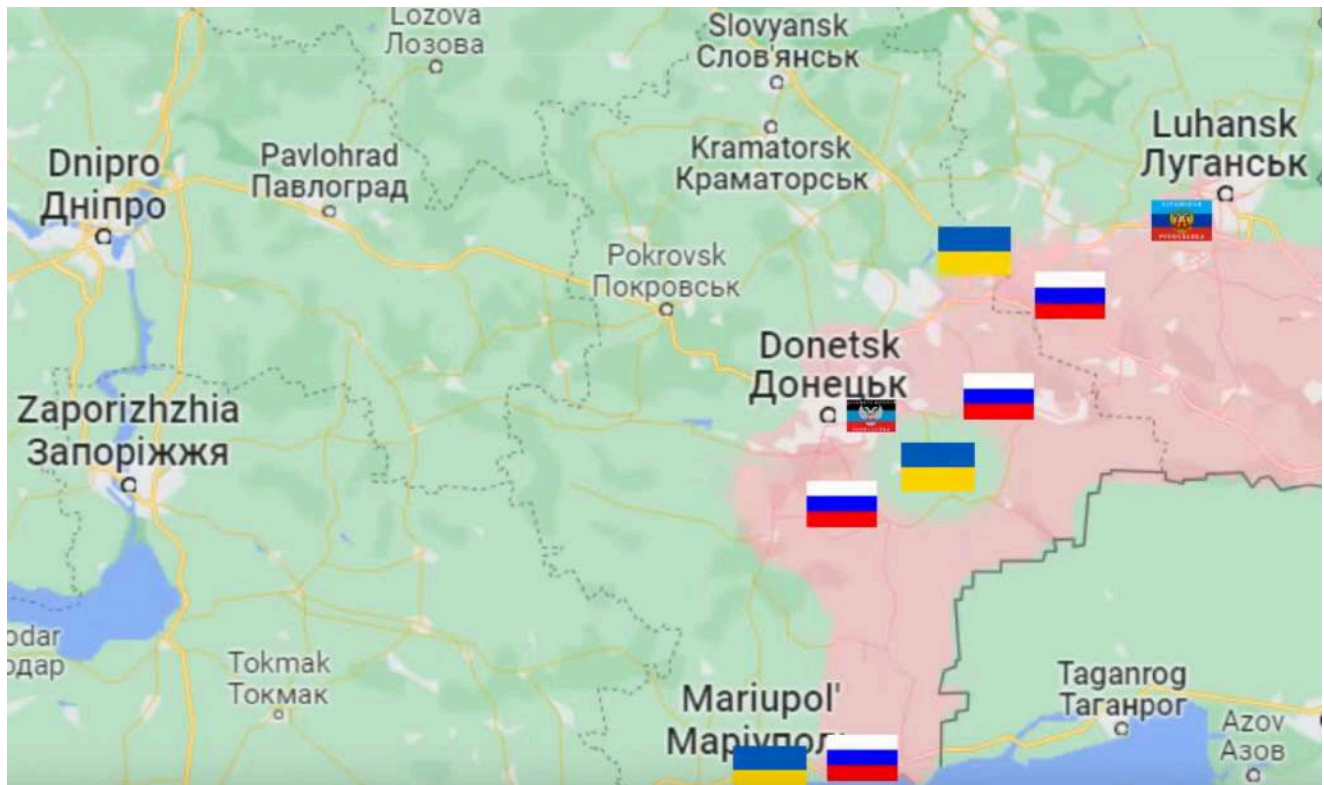
Chapter 2: Invasion (July 11th, 2014 - February 18th, 2015)

Starting on July 11, the Russian army launched a surprise artillery attack on Ukrainian bases from the Russian side of the border, killing dozens. When that didn't turn the tide, they gave the rebels a more advanced anti-air system, and you probably remember this part of the story.^[44]

Hours after the plane crashed, the wreckage was still smoldering in this dark and remote wheat field in eastern Ukraine—an area controlled by armed separatist fighters, an area that had seen intense fighting in the last week. At the time, Russian shot the passenger plane of Flight MH17 down. The Russians had now killed more civilians in a single shot than Ukraine had in the entire war up to this point, and it was only this that brought the hammer down from

the West. Obama had been responding to the annexation of Crimea with mostly symbolic personal sanctions. Now, the EU and America were sanctioning major Russian companies. So, Russia—now in for a penny, in for a pound—decided to launch a real invasion of Ukraine.. [\[45\]](#)

About four to five thousand soldiers, with tanks and IFVs, simply rolled into Ukraine, encircled a large chunk of Ukrainian forces, agreed to let them retreat through a humanitarian corridor, then changed their minds and killed everyone inside the pocket with artillery.



But a strange thing happened: in the face of this massive escalation, no one noticed. Russia had denied they had invaded, and everyone just decided to believe them. When Ukraine and the State Department provided satellite imagery showing Russian tank companies operating in Ukraine, maybe it made sense to ignore it and say, “Well, America lied about Iraq.” But it wasn’t just the Pentagon presenting evidence—for long [\[46\]](#)

Russian soldiers posted on Facebook about being sent and took selfies while on mission. There were also multiple Russian tankers taken prisoner by Ukraine, who were also saying in interviews that they had been ordered into the country. The Kremlin said that those Russians fighting in their government-issued kit were just volunteers on their summer break, and the tank crews had simply gotten lost and accidentally driven 50 miles into a war zone.

And amazingly, America’s pro-war, industrial-military-complex, consent-manufacturing, imperialist press just decided to take Russia at its word. And that’s still how they cover it. As far as I can tell, the only American publication that dropped the word *allegedly* when talking about Russian involvement in Ukraine is Vox. [\[46-1\]](#)

There was, however, one group of people who believed Ukraine — Russians themselves.

Quoting the father of a Russian soldier whose son was sent to Ukraine and later returned:

"In mid-August, he was sent to Ukraine as a paratrooper in the Ulyanovsk unit. At some point, their unit was ambushed. An anti-tank mortar—obviously, when it hits {his} leg, it blows it apart. From a healthy young lad, he was turned into a cripple. Our first meeting, we were in tears."^[29-3]

Regular Russian soldiers fighting in Ukraine meant Russian soldiers dying — not volunteers, but professionals under orders — leaving behind bewildered parents and widows. Widows entitled to monetary benefits. But acknowledging these deaths would mean refuting the premise of the war — namely, that this is all supposed to be a civil war. Russia probably only thought a handful of people would die, and it would be easy enough to hush it up. But more than 100 died in just the first month.

The Kremlin PR machine is powerful enough to spin away any Russian atrocity against Ukrainians, and it could certainly invent fictional Ukrainian atrocities. But what it couldn't do was spin away its own mistreatment of patriotic, duty-bound Russian soldiers and their families — especially when the Kremlin was increasingly relying on ultra-nationalists as its support base. For the Kremlin, the way out of this paradox was further radicalization

Independent media was shut down, and official media became more unhinged. NGOs for war widows were shut down. The government began rewriting history. [Boris Nemtsov](#) was murdered. Russia was beginning its lurch from a hybrid regime to a totalitarian life. ^[47]

Quoting the father once again:

In Russia, everybody puts the government first, they care about the unity of Russian as a nation and believe that Russian is surrounded by imperialism that is aiming to crush the country. One never knows. Is the country now split into a large group of patriots and a tiny group of same people?^[29-4]

But none of this would help if soldiers kept coming home in body bags. So Russia had to negotiate — and Ukraine had to negotiate, because it was defenseless and on its own. America wasn't sending military aid.

And let's stop again, because this was Russia's third off-ramp. It now had a buffer state in the occupied territories, plus everything it had before. It had thoroughly shown Ukraine who was boss, and it had demonstrated that America was not going to save them. But instead of taking that off-ramp — that isn't what happened^[48]. Russia agreed to pull its troops out of the country if, in exchange, Ukraine would give the East more autonomy, and both sides were to pull their artillery away from the front line. But instead yet again...

Battle of Debaltseve January 17th, 2015 - February 15th, 2015

Chaos struck in a matter of minutes, shattering the calm of a wintry Saturday morning in Mariupol on January 17th, 2015. Out of nowhere, rockets slammed into residential

neighborhoods, markets, even schools. Bodies lay strewn on the streets. This massacre, which killed 31 people in a single volley, turned the city of Mariupol against the rebels almost permanently. It also made heroes of the volunteer battalion assigned to defend the city.^[49]
^{[50][51]}

The Second Battle of Donetsk Airport began on September 28, 2014, and lasted until January 21, 2015. Russia launched a new offensive—this time targeting the Donetsk airport—immediately after signing a ceasefire agreement. Despite the agreement, Russia refused to withdraw its troops, claiming there were no Russian soldiers in Ukraine to begin with. To avoid further casualties among its own forces, Russia instead supplied the separatists with large quantities of heavy rocket artillery and told them to carry on the fight.^[52]

The rebels fired from densely populated residential neighborhoods, sparking an artillery war that leveled the towns surrounding the airport. After a brutal, three-month battle, the airport finally fell—not because it was captured, but because it was demolished, with the last Ukrainian defenders buried alive under the rubble. The cycle of peace negotiations, violations, artillery warfare, and eventual Russian-backed victory repeated itself.

A third attempt to seize Mariupol was also launched but aborted in favor of a random rocket barrage on the city center, defended at the time by the now-internationally known [Azov Brigade](#). By this point, with over 12,000 people dead, it looked like Russia might finally take off-ramp number five—and in a way, they did. At least, until 2022.^[52-1]

And we should pause here one last time, because it's worth emphasizing: Russia didn't actually win anything of material value in this war.

The territory it seized — parts of Donetsk and Luhansk — was economically devastated. Industrial infrastructure had been destroyed or abandoned, and much of the population had fled. What remained was a heavily sanctioned, war-torn region that required constant military and financial support just to maintain a fragile status quo. There were no vital natural resources gained, no strategic breakthrough, no new markets opened. Instead, Russia inherited a frozen conflict zone and an enormous long-term liability — both economically and politically. And yet, the cost wasn't just material. It came with over 12,000 lives lost by this point, international sanctions that deeply hurt the Russian economy, the beginning of its pariah status in the West, and the radicalization and authoritarian turn of its domestic politics.
^[53]

The so-called "victory" had come at a staggering price — but the war wasn't even over yet.
^[53-1]

Chapter 3: Aftermath (February 18th, 2015 - February 24th, 2022)

Ukraine was already ineligible to join NATO, and the war only served to make the country more militarized and deeply anti-Russian. Yet, despite all the odds, Ukraine did win — and it did so in a way that would have major consequences for the world. Russia, against all

expectations, accomplished something that should have been impossible: it invaded and brutalized a neighboring country in broad daylight — and emerged with a better international reputation than before.^[54]

Half of the West, at best, was more sympathetic to Russia than to Ukraine. Much of the rest of the world was convinced the invasion either never happened or was somehow Ukraine's fault — usually blamed on “Nazis” or other pretexts.^[54-1] The sheer scale of this gaslighting achievement is staggering. Imagine fighting a war against a country so skilled at rewriting reality that half the world believes you were at risk of committing genocide against speakers of a language you yourself speak.

To illustrate this, consider this list of prominent Ukrainian nationalist political figures — all of whom grew up speaking Russian:

- Yulia Tymoshenko
- Petro Poroshenko
- Dmytro Yarosh
- Volodymyr Zelensky
- Oleksandr Turchynov
- Andriy Biletski
- Semyon Semenchenko
- Ihor Kolomoyski
- Serhii Taruta
- Volodymyr Groysman

And so that begs the question: how did Russia pull this off? How did it manage to convince so much of the world to accept its narrative?

There are some mundane reasons. One is timing. Russia's full-scale attack on Ukraine coincided with the rise of ISIS. The month the war heated up in Slovyansk was the same month ISIS conquered [Mosul](#). And the week Russia launched its real invasion was the same week ISIS released the horrifying video of [James Foley](#)'s beheading. With global attention riveted on the terror threat in the Middle East, the war in Ukraine struggled to break through the news cycle. This allowed Russia to flood the information space with disinformation, creating doubt and confusion, while much of the world's focus was elsewhere.

Also, there wasn't much real effort from the West to push back. Both Europe and the White House were convinced this was a situation that needed de-escalation rather than a case of Russia acting opportunistically. In reality, they just wanted the conflict to disappear as quickly as possible.

At the same time, Russia was deploying a tactical approach that the West came to call **hybrid warfare**—a concept that became a major focus in Pentagon discussions. Hybrid warfare blends conventional military action with terrorism, cyber warfare, propaganda, and more. Russia's war on Ukraine certainly involved terrorism. For example, the bombing of the

Unity Rally in Kharkiv on February 22nd, 2015, targeted civilians directly. Throughout the conflict, Russia bombed dozens of civilian sites in western Ukraine while simultaneously conducting regular military operations. [\[55\]](#)

And that bombing campaign later expanded to NATO territory [\[56\]](#), and it certainly involved cyber war too. Russia brought down the power grid, and countless institutions got hacked, but the effect of both was marginal at best on the outcome. I suspect the real magic behind Russia's information war was not that it really succeeded in hiding Russian crimes, but how it distorted time by broadening the gap between when something happened and when the Western media could finally be forced to report it happened.

Sequences of events could be presented out of order. Russia could act aggressively, trigger Ukrainian retaliation, present that retaliation as if it were unprovoked, and then a week later, when Russia's initial act of aggression was reported, Russia could just present it as retaliation for what the Ukrainians had done first. It didn't matter at that point what had actually occurred first because no one in the West was paying enough attention.

So an invasion of Crimea that started on February 24th could be presented as retaliation for the formation of a fascist junta that hadn't been appointed to government until February 27th. And so Russia could fire artillery from dense residential neighborhoods and then call it an atrocity when the Ukrainians fired back, and Russia could point the finger at Ukraine for not following the Minsk agreements after it launched three massive bloody offensives immediately after signing the Minsk agreement.

And the F-word [Gravel Institute](#) can present a war in 2014 as having been provoked by a law, and here I quote:

"Eastern Ukrainians were horrified at what they saw as a far-right seizure of power, with veneration of Bandera and an elimination of equal recognition for languages like Russian. {...} Service industry workers have, since January, been obliged to talk to customers in Ukrainian unless clients specifically ask to switch."

But all that — that wasn't passed until 2019, and here is the evidence: [Law of Ukraine "To ensure the functioning of the Ukrainian language as the State language"](#). This, of course, had a multiplying effect on populists because the mainstream media coverage, which was already hopelessly biased in favor of Russia, was assumed by anti-establishment types to be biased in favor of Ukraine — because that was at least nominally the side America had taken. So populists took even more extreme anti-Ukraine positions to compensate for the pro-Ukraine media bias they were sure they were reading. But I still don't find any of these reasons totally convincing. And of course, none of this explains why Russia, eight years later, decided to launch a full-scale war in which it had nothing to gain and could not win. So, coming up in next Part, we'll talk about what some of the "most intelligent" and "well-respected" theorists like [John J. Mearsheimer](#), who teaches Political Science at the University of Chicago say — and why they're all idiotically wrong.

Part III: A survey of all the popular theories of why Russia invaded Ukraine and why they're wrong, and a history of American foreign policy in Eastern Europe, especially NATO expansion.



Part in which I talk about NATO Expansion, partly to debunk the idea that it caused the war but mostly as a springboard for explaining the evolution of the Russian-American relationship

📖 "A serious problem in planning against American doctrine is that the Americans do not read their manuals, nor do they feel any obligation to follow their doctrine"

- by Anonymous Soviet Warplanner

So, let's cut to the chase here.

Why — what did Russia, or at least Putin, think he had to gain by starting this war? It's easy to forget now, with Russia struggling to hold on to its marginal gains, that this was supposed to be the easy part. Even if Russia had gotten its three-day victory in the conventional war, there was always an even bigger quagmire waiting for them there at the finish line.

If they installed a friendly government and left, it would immediately be overthrown. If they stayed, they'd have to face an insurgency. And if they tried to just stop at conquering half the country, they'd have to defend a more than 800 km long border. So what was the plan here? I've heard a lot of theories.

From Putin going after Ukraine's natural gas reserves^[57] to a theory that the Kremlin is enthralled to insane philosophers who all talk like Final Fantasy villains.

An actual quote from the philosopher whom the Head of the Ministry of Defence in Russia congratulated for his knowledge and understanding of the world, and who was later awarded a Russian literature prize:

"Every so-called truth is a matter of believing, so we believe in what we do, we believe in what we say, and that is the only way to define the truth."

American cable news pundits seemed to switch between thinking it's because he's gone covet isolation crazy or because he's always harbored a secret desire to reunify the USSR. For instance, did you know that Vladimir Putin once said and here I quote all expert I have

found saying the same, that: "The collapse of the Soviet Empire was a great tragedy," or as Secretary of U.S. at the first Trump term, [John Bolton](#) puts it: "Vladimir Putin was the man who described the collapse of the USSR as the greatest geopolitical catastrophe." [Johnny Harris](#) on his YouTube channel says: "The collapse of the Soviet Union, quote, 'the greatest catastrophe.'" Even [Ian Bremmer](#) from TED Talk continues: "The greatest geopolitical tragedy, the greatest tragedy of the 20th century." Similarly, the CNN reporter [Susan Glasser](#) states: "Not just a great tragedy but the greatest geopolitical catastrophe in the 20th century—never mind World War II."

But even Putin can't decide on a single story. One day he's claiming he needs to resolve the imaginary humanitarian crisis in Donetsk, and the next he's writing insane 7,000-word essays on how Ukraine and Russia are spiritually bonded^[58]. And what about the Russian people? Why are they going along with this? Theories seem to range from them being completely propagandized to them all just being mindless Orcs. It's hard not to feel like all of these theories leave a lot to be desired, even if you combine them. However, there's one theory I feel compelled to debunk in detail because it is very specific, it's materialist, it's intuitive, and you sound like a rational big-brain geopolitics understander when you repeat it. It embodies a whole historical narrative of Russian-American relations that is very popular—even among opponents of Putin's war.

This is, of course, the theory that Russia is acting in preemptive self-defense—self-defense against American aggression—best embodied by America's decision to expand NATO to Eastern Europe, including potentially Ukraine.

As George Bush puts it:

"In Washington, the foreign ministers of Canada, Denmark, Iceland, Italy, Norway, Portugal, and the United States signed with the nations of Western Union the North Atlantic Pact. This was no treaty aimed at aggression but a pledge to cooperate in defense of the peace."

For those catching up, NATO is a mutual defense pact: if one country is attacked, every other country in NATO is obliged to help defend it. But if one country decides to go out on its own and start a war, the rest of NATO can say, "You're on your own." Since the alliance was founded at the start of the Cold War to deter Soviet power creep, expanding it eastward could reasonably be interpreted as an attempt to strangle Russia at a time when America was supposed to be softening its posture towards Russia. After all, how would America like it if China formed a military alliance with Mexico?

But in many ways, the theory that America provoked the war through NATO expansion isn't just about NATO—it's an elaborate narrative of 30 years of American aggression and Russian victimization^[59].

There are several lectures that have gotten very popular on YouTube that explain this narrative^[60], but the most watched is this one from renowned international relations scholar

John Mearsheimer, and as he states:

“The Russians didn’t conquer or invade Crimea because they had a leasing agreement. There’s a naval base at Sevastopol, and the Russians were leasing that naval base from Ukraine, so they had military forces there.”^[60-1]

John Mearsheimer has developed a reputation among certain communities as the [Cassandra](#) of the Russo-Ukrainian war and, as a result, has become an extremely polarizing figure. I've linked his lecture and others in the footnotes, but for the sake of brevity, I'll summarize. Allow me to present the great NATO sob story of 1991–2014 as it is not 100% accurately told across the globe:

It's 1990, and U.S. Secretary of State [Jim Bakker](#) and Chairman of the USSR [Mikhail Gorbachev](#) are negotiating what to do about Germany now that the wall has come down. Gorbachev wants Germany to leave NATO, and America wants Germany to stay in NATO even after it absorbs East Germany. So, in order to get Gorbachev's agreement to let East Germany join NATO, Jim Bakker promised America would never expand NATO to any countries east of Germany.

That should have been the happy end of the story, but America had other plans. Because soon after that meeting, America immediately engineered the collapse of the Soviet Union, then forced a newly born country of Russia to destroy its own economy by privatizing too much^[61] or too quickly^[61-1], or by giving Russia not enough aid money^[61-2], or by giving Russia too much aid money^[61-3] (as [Naomi Klein](#) in her book [The Shock Doctrine](#) tells), or by conditioning the aid too much (as [Globalization and Its Discontents](#) by [Joseph E. Stiglitz](#) states), or by conditioning the aid not enough^[61-4] (like [Stephen F. Cohen](#) writes in his book [Failed Crusade](#)), or something else entirely — each has their own story^[61-5] ... I don't know, it depends on who you ask. Everyone kind of glosses over this point.

Then, with Russia crippled, America went back on its word and annexed Poland, Czechia, and Hungary into NATO, then lied about there ever having been an agreement. Then it refused to let Russia join NATO, proving the open-door policy was a lie and that the expansion was aimed more towards hemming in Russia. Then it bombed Serbia for no reason, tore up the anti-ballistic missile treaty, immediately started building interceptors, then it annexed the Baltic states, putting NATO troops and missiles within spitball range of Saint Petersburg.

And it was only finally when America was getting ready to finish the job by annexing Georgia and Ukraine that Russia decided it had no choice but to push back and defend itself by invading first Georgia and then Ukraine. But the American empire, drunk on its arrogance and the blood of countless brown people, instead of taking no for an answer, refused to acknowledge Russia's right to defend itself, forcing Russia to escalate.

That's the story, or stories, anyway.

Now, did America actually say and do those things? Some of it, but there's a lot of missing context, and, well, it might be easier to go back to the beginning. Let's roll the tape back and start over in 1990. By the time the summit convened that morning, President Bush and Secretary of State Baker had shifted its spot. So, in a meeting, Jim Baker does make an offer to not expand NATO eastward, but it's not clear if he meant within Germany or in Europe as a whole. Before you can discuss it further, President Bush tells him to take the offer back—for a very convoluted set of reasons.^{[62][63]}

Gorbachev comes away believing that he has an implicit agreement that NATO won't expand. Why didn't Gorbachev push for an explicit agreement? Because he was desperate for cash.

As the media and news reported in 1990:

“But the Soviet president's biggest headache is surely the economy, deteriorating by the day. Westerners who work in the Soviet Union say it's like living in a third world country. ‘Upper Volta with rockets’ is the way one put it.”

Gorbachev was taking heat from all sides: the leaders of the republics wanted more autonomy, the people wanted an end to empty shelves, and the hardliners in the KGB wanted Gorbachev to focus on holding together the empire. So, to keep his head above water, Gorbachev brought together a team of experts and economists, and they created a plan for a relatively quick but orderly transition from an entirely state-run economy to a mixed market economy.

The plan was called the 500 Days program, and it would keep the union together, get food back on the shelves, and provide enough autonomy for the republics to be happy without having to dissolve the Soviet Union. But for it to work, the Soviet Union was going to need a lot of aid money.^[64] So Gorbachev spent the first half of 1991 going around the West trying to sell the plan, and the answer he got back from the United States was: “maybe later”. Well, that's fine—Gorbachev would just have to hold on for another year. He was still getting money from the Germans, and with that, he could buy it... but the loose plan never saw the light of day, as a coup d'état happened.^[65]

They first moved in at 4 a.m., the first sign of the coup d'état that removed Mikhail Gorbachev from power. With tanks in Red Square, the official word from the new government, calling itself the National Emergency Committee, was that the architect of glasnost and perestroika was too ill to continue in office. [Gennady Yanayev](#), back then Acting President of the USSR, said:

“Mikhail Gorbachev is now on vacation. He is very tired after these many years, and he will need some time to get better.”

Furthermore, thousands still gathered in Leningrad's Palace Square to demonstrate against the coup and cheer their republic leader [Boris Yeltsin](#). Supporters reacted with their bare hands, building makeshift barricades with whatever pieces of disused machinery or

brickwork were available. Speaking around the Russian Federation building, people were defying the 11 p.m. to 5 a.m. curfew. The people there said that they do not obey the laws of the military junta; they obey only the laws of Russia and the decrees of Boris Yeltsin.

There also has been a report from Reuters, the British news agency, that three people were shot dead outside the Russian Parliament by Soviet tank crews. Furthermore, military convoys were seen heading out of Moscow. Tank drivers confirmed the coup was ending. Two people manning the barricades here—the first sign the coup was faltering—laid in the fact there was no all-out attack on the Russian Federation headquarters. The withdrawal came after dissension had developed in the military. At least two crack airborne divisions revealed they had thrown their allegiance to Yeltsin less than three days after being placed under house arrest by communist hardliners. The Soviet president was to return to Moscow to retake the reins of government. The fate of the coup plotters remains unknown.

At the end of the rally, the Russian flag was hoisted above the Parliament building in place of the hammer and sickle. Tens of thousands of people outside Boris Yeltsin's headquarters were elated. In their view, he had saved the day. Victoriously, they waved the Russian flag, and one speaker said the “Black Knight of fear” had become a new day of freedom.^[65-1]

The attempted coup of August 1991 only lasted three days, but that was more than enough to convince Ukraine that it couldn't wait for a compromise anymore. It declared independence five days later, but you already know the rest of Ukraine's story. Russia, on the other hand, faced the prospect of a majority Muslim and Asian Soviet Union, so Russia decided to quit the union too and refocus on rebuilding its economy under the guidance of its newly sovereign president, Boris Yeltsin^[65-2].

But the now Russian reformers realized they faced a much darker choice. Unlike the other republics, the power ministries of the Russian state—the KGB, the ministers of heavy industries, and the military-industrial complex—were still being run by people either involved with or at least sympathetic to the coup. Yeltsin became convinced that if he wanted to stave off another reactionary push, he'd have to disband them^[66]. He also believed the only way to get a market system in place was to do it all at once, in order to make it a *fait accompli* before anyone could stop him. Even though this would mean privatizing property before actually having a way of protecting property rights, or ending price controls without controlling the money supply, or restructuring the economy without building a social safety net—in other words, their choice was between destroying the state or going back to the Brezhnev era.

So, the reformers became revolutionaries, and Russia's experiment in social democracy became an experiment in anarcho-capitalism, with predictable results. Some prices jumped even more than the three, four, or five times they'd expected. Bottles was selling for eight times the price it could have been pulled for yesterday.

In 1993, President Yeltsin emerged as the winner of a bloody power struggle with his opponents in Parliament and their allies on the streets outside the building. Bodies still lay

where they fell. There was still no official estimate of the number killed inside, though the city medical authorities said nearly 500 had been treated for injuries. And in 1994, over one weekend, Russia sent a force of more than 40,000 into the Republic of Chechnya, heading towards the capital of Grozny. On-site, the troops from Russia's Interior Ministries scrambled at the sight of an approaching armored personnel carrier. They didn't know if it was one of theirs or one of the Chechens. As it passed, they opened fire wildly, still none the wiser who they were firing at.

Furthermore, in 1996, Steravotova was gunned down in the hallway of her St. Petersburg apartment in late November. Most Russians regard the killing of this pro-democracy Member of Parliament as a political murder and as evidence that their country's post-Soviet reform era was ending. For the Russian people, democracy is synonymous with criminal anarchy; they don't understand democracy as the working rule of law mechanisms. Later, in 1998, amidst the anarchy, Russians tried to withdraw their savings from banks while the country's financial system appeared to teeter on the brink of collapse. And so, in August the same year, the government virtually defaulted on its debt and the ruble crashed. One year later, Russia continued to pound villages with their heavy guns—a tactic which Chechens say has caused numerous civilian casualties—and at times Russian soldiers shut down the Ingushetia border and even shot fleeing refugees. Forward another five years to 2004, when commandos stormed a school in southern Russia where militants held hundreds of hostages. Russian news accounts said more than 200 people were killed, more than 70 of them children.

So what to make of this chaos and pure mayhem? In short, let us say: an inflation crisis, a parliamentary crisis, a street crime crisis, an organized crime crisis, an official corruption crisis, an alcoholism crisis, a banking crisis, a sovereign debt crisis, two civil wars, and an Islamist insurgency—all in the span of 10 years.

Meanwhile, in America, Bill Clinton took office in 1993 with zero years of foreign policy experience on a platform 100% focused on domestic issues. He immediately faced a dilemma^[67]. And the KGB hardliners who forced this outcome would spend the next 30 years blaming foreigners and Jews.

With Russia on fire it looked like there's already a 50/50 chance it's a lost cause for the next 20 years. Unless you do something to protect the other countries of Eastern Europe, they might get dragged down with it. But if you make moves on those countries, Russians would interpret it as aggression, and you might accidentally push Russia into the abyss by trying to hedge your bets. When being nice to Russia might move it closer to America, the foreign policy establishment in America—those who were for expansion of NATO, like [Anthony Lake](#) (National Security Advisor 1993–97), [Henry Kissinger](#) (National Security Advisor 1969–75 and Secretary of State 1973–77), and [Zbigniew Brzezinski](#) (National Security Advisor 1977–81)—seemed to be almost split 50/50 with the opposition to the expansion of NATO, which included [William Perry](#) (Secretary of Defense 1994–97), [George Kennan](#) (Ambassador to the USSR, 1952), and even [George Soros](#), US philanthropist and perennial scapegoat, who too opposed the idea.

So why did America ultimately decide to take its chances with antagonizing an incredibly unstable Russia? That's where the agency of Eastern Europe comes in. You will sometimes see people who supported NATO expansion complain that the NATO expansion sob story ignores the fact that Eastern Europe wanted to join NATO, saying America expanded NATO basically treats these countries as pawns rather than real people with real aspirations. But that argument's wrong because even that argument understates Eastern Europe's agency. Countries like Poland didn't get into NATO by just begging until America took pity—Poland **blackmailed** its way into NATO.^[68]

In 1994, Bill Clinton's first plan for Eastern Europe was not to expand NATO outright but rather to create a NATO "holding room" called the Partnership for Peace (PfP). As Bill Clinton himself said:

"This partnership will advance a process of evolution for NATO's formal enlargement. It looks to the day when NATO will take on new members who assume the alliance's full responsibilities. It will create a framework in which former Communist states and others not now members of NATO can participate with NATO members in joint military planning, training exercises, and other efforts."

With the PfP, everyone in Europe could join at once with little fanfare. PfP allowed Eastern Europe and America's military to collaborate, facilitating their democratic transition. It also meant you could do all the prep work for letting countries into NATO without formally announcing it and hurting Russia's feelings. But for the three countries at the western edge of Eastern Europe—Poland, Hungary, and Czechoslovakia (which later split into Czechia and Slovakia)—this was not good enough. They wanted a security guarantee. They wanted NATO's Article 5—the promise that an attack on one is an attack on all. No one wanted it more than Poland.

So the President of Poland [Aleksander Kwasniewski](#) invited Boris Yeltsin to a state dinner, got him drunk, and tricked him into signing a letter saying that Russia didn't mind Poland joining NATO. When that didn't work, Polish officials started implying that without Article 5 protection, Poland would have no choice but to defend itself by pursuing a nuclear weapons program. And when that didn't work, Eastern Europe moved on from the nuclear option and tried the *real* nuclear option: they started coming to Washington and meeting with Republicans—the opposition party to Clinton.^[69]

You have to understand, it wasn't just the names—like [Lech Wałęsa](#)—that carried a lot of weight internationally. There were also huge émigré communities from these countries living in the United States, many of whom had settled in the swing states of the Midwest. Wałęsa even implied they would campaign for the Republicans, which terrified Democrats. That fear only grew after the Democrats were wiped out in the 1994 midterm elections. So Clinton gave in, stateting:

"While the Partnership for Peace wasn't NATO membership, neither was it a permanent holding pen—it changed the entire NATO dialogue. Now, the question wasn't whether

NATO would take on new members but *when* and *how* it would happen." [69-1]

There were good—good but ultimately wrong—reasons to think Russia might still tolerate this provocation and keep moving toward the West, even possibly joining NATO. One reason was China. It wasn't hard to predict that the main challenge to American hegemony in the coming decades would come from a rapidly growing nuclear power with four times America's population. Plus, the Chinese government wasn't as notoriously mercurial. So one outcome America was banking on was that Russia would realize it had more to fear from China than from America and would look to America for protection.

But from Russia's point of view, Chinese unpredictability was actually a reason *not* to join NATO, since joining NATO would put Russia on the front lines of any China-America confrontation. Russia also constantly sent mixed signals. In addition to the permission letter Yeltsin gave Poland, Russia could never get its story straight on what exactly its objections to NATO expansion were. Sometimes they seemed to want NATO in its entirety replaced by a militarized OSCE. Sometimes Yeltsin's officials claimed they didn't actually mind if NATO expanded, but they were worried about how nationalists and voters within Russia would react.^[70] Most often, opponents of NATO expansion complained that it humiliated Russia. "I'm not persuaded by the assurances we hear that Russia has nothing to worry about," they said. "You cannot humiliate a nation—a people—and think it will have no consequences."

But complaining about humiliation was probably the worst way to convince America *not* to expand NATO, because from America's point of view, humiliation is just an inevitable part of losing empire. The Dutch had to be humiliated at Surabaya, the British at Suez, the French at Orléans, and America in Saigon—and they all got over it, kind of... [70-1]

Losing your empire *is* supposed to be humiliating. You did a bad thing, so Russia would just have to get over it—or at least, that's what was hoped. As Joe Biden put it back then:

"The Kremlin's public opposition to enlargement, in my view, is largely a question of a psychological problem they are undergoing now — connected with the loss of empire, wounded pride, and most importantly uncertainty about Russia's place in the world of the 21st century. And were you in their spot, you would be the same, in my view. I mean, I know, I would."

But here's an important piece of context that often gets lost: Clinton didn't just announce NATO expansion unilaterally — he went to Yeltsin and got Yeltsin to agree to let it happen. Because here's the thing about NATO expansion—Russia was actually powerful enough to prevent it.

They had demonstrated that power back in 1992, when Russia ran the same playbook in Moldova that it would use in Ukraine 22 years later. The president of Moldova at the time accused Russia of waging an undeclared war against his former Soviet republic. Russian members of a former Soviet Red Army stationed in Moldova were fighting alongside Slavic separatists against the Moldovan government, funding an ethnic separatist war that divided

the country *de facto* but not *de jure*, using the violence to arm-twist Moldova into a guarantee never to join NATO. Even if Moldova hadn't been forced into this position, Russia still had a lot of leverage through nuclear proliferation. Everyone understood this, they just didn't like saying it out loud.

So when Yeltsin publicly complained that NATO expansion violated the unwritten agreement made during German reunification, the United States responded publicly that there was no such agreement and that it didn't need Russia's permission. But behind the scenes, Clinton was trying to buy Yeltsin's cooperation. ^[71] Clinton gave Yeltsin \$4.5 billion in aid, promised that no nuclear weapons would be deployed in the new member states, agreed that no major conventional weapons or permanent bases would be stationed in those countries, and, most importantly, they agreed not to announce any of this until the autumn of 1996. ^[71-1]

Why was the timing so important? Because Russia held its presidential elections on July 3, 1996, and the U.S. held its presidential election just a few months later on November 5, 1996. That fall was the Goldilocks period — early enough to help Clinton politically, but late enough to minimize the political damage to Yeltsin.

By 1999 — NATO's 50th anniversary and ten years after the fall of the Berlin Wall — the plan was that the first group of invitees would become full-fledged NATO members. But why lie about it?

For one, it served the political interests of both countries. For Clinton, it allowed him to appear tough to Republicans, who were rapidly hostile to anything that looked like multilateralism, while also keeping America's options open for the future. Acknowledging a Russian veto would have meant effectively repudiating the Helsinki Final Act — the treaty that guaranteed European countries the right to choose their own alliances. More importantly, for Yeltsin, it was political cover against nationalists for taking the deal. He wasn't trading away Poland just to raise campaign cash — he was being steamrolled by America despite his best efforts. And in the end, the deal worked for both Yeltsin and Clinton.

But the relationship between Yeltsin and Clinton was somewhat special. While they personally liked each other, they couldn't bridge the deep trust gap between their countries. Their efforts to bring America and Russia closer together were constantly sabotaged by their own legislatures and by accusations that they were selling their countries out. Soon enough, both would be replaced by far more aggressive successors — George W. Bush in the U.S. in 2001, and Putin in Russia.

With Bush, there was far less nuance. He unilaterally tore up the Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty without giving Congress or Russia much of a heads-up. He invaded Iraq, convincing much of the world that America was too megalomaniacal to be trusted as the world's police. He started building missile interceptors in Europe. And perhaps most provocatively, he pushed to get Ukraine and Georgia into NATO's Membership Action Plan — directly against the advice of France, Germany, and several of his own advisors. Unlike Clinton, Bush offered Russia no trade-offs or negotiations; he just did it out of the blue. ^[72]

And boy, did Russia respond — just three years after NATO's expansion, in 2008, Russia launched a six-day war with Georgia. So, case closed, right? The great NATO sob story is basically right: if America had just shown more restraint with NATO, Russia wouldn't have invaded Ukraine. Sure, the NATO argument does help explain — if not justify — Russia's invasion of Georgia. But we're talking about Ukraine here, not Georgia. And there were six years between those two conflicts.

It's during those six years that the great NATO sob story shifts from having some validity to straight-up shameless lying. It was actually in 2008 that this narrative gained a lot of traction, both inside the U.S. foreign policy establishment — with voices like [Thomas Friedman](#) — and outside it, like [Joshua Keating](#). ^[73]

Why did George Bush do this? Why scare the Russians for no reason, if there wasn't really any plan yet to let Ukraine in NATO? I have a theory that I cannot prove, but feel pretty confident in. I think it was a political favor to Viktor Yushchenko, who Bush had gotten close to over the previous 4 years. If you go back to part I of this series, you'll remember that 2008 is when Yushchenko's presidency was starting to go off the rails, and even then, it was looking like he wouldn't get reelected. What I suspect was happening was that Bush was trying to give Yushchenko something, anything, that Yushchenko could present to his voters as some kind of progress in stabilizing the country.

John Mearsheimer's brand of realism and his call for restraint won a lot of admirers. One of them was the 44th President of the United States, Barack Obama. As Obama put it himself:

"In a cold war in which Muslim-majority countries were too often treated as proxies without regard to their own aspirations {...} I've come here to Cairo to seek a new beginning once."

When Obama became president, Russia was allowed back into the G8. A deal was made to move missile interceptors out of Europe and onto boats in the Black Sea. While the U.S. never publicly renounced the idea of letting Ukraine and Georgia into NATO, Obama also made clear that countries needed to have full territorial integrity and hold referenda to join. Georgia, with its ongoing territorial conflicts, did not meet that standard.



And in Ukraine, a majority of the population was against entering NATO.



REPORT | MARCH 29, 2010



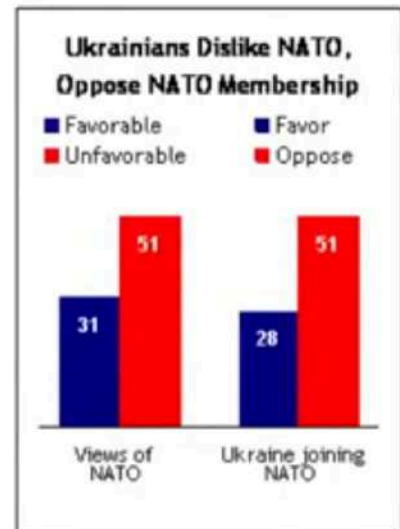
Ukraine Says 'No' to NATO

by Kathleen Holzwart Sprehe, Research Associate, Pew Global Attitudes Project

Ukraine's new governing coalition recently announced its intention to pass a law against joining military alliances, which will fulfill Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovich's campaign promise to prevent Ukraine from becoming a member in NATO. The new president's opponents in parliament argue that this new strategy may result in pushing Ukraine back into the Russian "sphere of influence" and out of the European fold.

However, Yanukovich's move to ban Ukraine from joining NATO is not without a base of public support. A

[September 2009 survey by the Pew Research Center's](#)



The Ukrainians moved on, elected Yanukovich, and agreed to host a Russian military base on Crimea for the next 30 years, blocking itself out of NATO until 2040. This rapprochement worked at first: Russia agreed to a massive reduction in strategic nuclear arms, agreed to let American troops travel through Russia to Afghanistan, and put sanctions on Iran to pressure them into nuclear talks. Then the Euromaidan happened, and Russia went crazy, killed thousands of innocent people, and scapegoated America for it anyway. No one in America could see any compelling reason for why it happened. That's why people like Barack Obama and Angela Merkel kept bending over backwards to offer Russia off-ramps. It's not because they liked or respected Russians more than other Eastern Europeans; it's just that they'd both more or less come to the conclusion that Vladimir Putin had simply made a mistake out of pique and could thus be lured back with the right encouragement.

But as we went over in Part II, not only did Putin refuse every off-ramp, he kept escalating throughout 2014 despite already having a practical assurance that Ukraine couldn't join NATO. Then, even though America couldn't even be bothered to send Ukraine weapons, Russia decided to escalate the Ukraine conflict further into a second Cold War by attacking

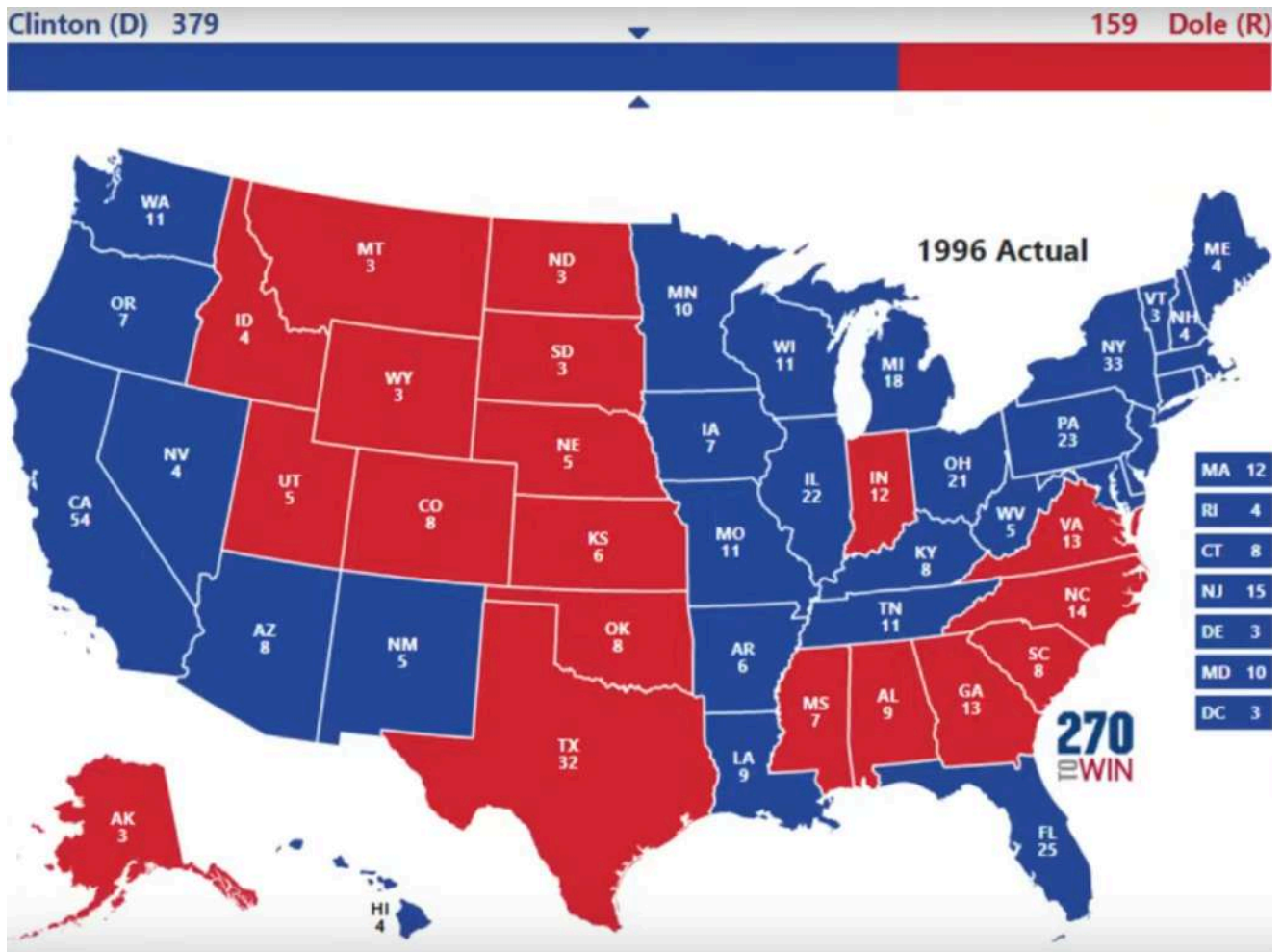
the American elections in 2016 — that Trump now calls the “Russian hoax” and “made up stories”.

A move that completely backfired and led to America sending Ukraine weapons. This is Putin’s master tactical plan. The people who made their name on The Great NATO sob story, like John Mearsheimer, just kind of skipped this part. That’s why Washington hates these people — it’s not because he’s telling them hard truths they don’t want to hear, it’s because America did what Putin wanted for six years, and when that didn’t work, instead of admitting fault he (John Mearsheimer) just furiously rewrote history to blame them so he could pretend he was still right. That type of careerist historical revisionism would be forgivable if there was nothing at stake but his reputation — but there is substantially more at stake now... the whole Ukraine, in fact, and the foundation of the liberal order, and many more things too many to list...

But still the idiocracy persists, and in the words of John Mearsheimer at one of his California university lectures states:

“There are many people who say the Russians are going to go on a rampage, they’re going to try and re-establish the Soviet Union or greater Russia and so forth and so on. Uh, that’s not going to happen. Uh, Putin is much too smart for that. You remember what happened when the Russians invaded Afghanistan? You remember what happened when we invaded Afghanistan? You remember what happened when we invaded Iraq? Remember what happened when the Israelis invaded Southern Lebanon? You want to stay out of these places. In fact, if you really want to wreck Russia, what you should do is encourage it to try and conquer Ukraine. Putin, again, is much too smart to do that.”

So, was NATO expansion a bad idea? Maybe. Probably... yes. **Yes, it was.** At a time when America should have been paying special attention to stabilizing Russian democracy, Bill Clinton corrupted that relationship in order to rush through a policy that didn’t need to be rushed — to satisfy a special interest voting block for an October surprise campaign stunt in an election that he would have won anyway!



And everyone in Washington just kind of crossed their fingers and hoped everything would work out because it was, after all, the end of history.

But does NATO's expansion justify Russia's war on Ukraine? Not in the moral sense — just in an amoral geopolitical sense? The answer is a definitive no! You see, the point of the NATO sob story isn't really geopolitics; it's about making the case that America is especially evil and duplicitous. America is not especially duplicitous. America is not anything, because countries are not actually sentient balls or memes with enduring personality traits... they are ideas. America can't have a duplicitous foreign policy; it doesn't have a foreign policy at all.

Presidents have foreign policies, and there's less continuity between them than people would like to imagine. For instance, when Yeltsin first started complaining about how NATO expansion violated an agreement with James Bakker, there was no one in the State Department who had worked for Bush on Russian issues anymore, and the Clinton guys had barely been briefed by their predecessors. So, they had to spend a week just tracking down retired German and American officials to ask what Boris Yeltsin was talking about. But the great NATO sob story isn't interesting because it's true or because it's false — it's interesting because it illustrates the perennial problem of foreign relations between democracies and autocracies.

Autocracies tend to see the chaotic wheeling and dealing of democracies as malicious subterfuge. And democracies tend to think their problems within autocracy will be solved by the next regime change. So, hurt feelings are almost guaranteed in the Russian-American relationship. But hurt feelings are not the basis of a sound foreign policy. Even if Russia was

right to feel entitled to a sphere of influence encompassing all the former Soviet Union, attacking Ukraine wasn't going to reverse the Baltics' entry into NATO, and it didn't prevent Ukraine from joining NATO because Ukraine wasn't joining NATO in the first place. And even if it was, Russia could have stopped Crimea. Also — and I cannot believe this needs to be explained to freaking geopolitics experts like John Mearsheimer — Russia has a nuclear deterrent; they do not need land buffers at all.

There's nothing realist about substituting resentment for actually making sure a war will make your country stronger. Did resentment play a role? Sure, probably, along with Putin's fear of his domestic opposition, all the weird hyper-nationalist philosophers, and he probably really does believe this goofy spiritual thing about Ukrainians and Russians being one people^[58-1]. But even if you combine all that, there's still a big missing piece — and I think I have found that missing piece. But it is a weird, weird story — like a [Thomas Pynchon](#) novel weird story... So buckle in, we've got the last part to discuss...

Part IV: The American Origins of Putin's Madness & The incredibly stupid and insane story of a fringe political sect and how it connects to both the war and a lot of other terrible things that have happened in the last 10 years.

Tldr

Having exhausted all rationalist economic and geopolitical explanations for the war in Ukraine. We dive into the maelstrom of self-exculpation, paranoia, and historical revisionism that has characterized not just modern Russia, but the world in general this past decade, to try and find out if perhaps the lies we tell about the past have a stronger influence on our future than we'd like to think.

☞ **The most widely practiced disguise and justification of imperialism, has, however, always been the ideology of anti-imperialism. It is so widely used because it is the most effective of all ideologies of imperialism"**

- Hans Morganthau, "Politics Among Nations"

The thing about trying to track down the origin of a conspiracy theory is it's a lot like trying to track down the origin of a river: there are so many branches and backwaters contributing to a river you can never entirely pin down which specific branch can rightly be called the origin.

Chapter 1: Washington 2003 (The Iraq War)

After 9/11, America launched multiple wars of aggression, created a global system of enforced disappearance and torture, tore up international law, intentionally pitted Western Europe against Eastern Europe, and massively destabilized the Middle East.

I'm not interested in making a comparison between the war in Iraq and the war in Ukraine. What I am interested in is the similarities between America itself—its political culture in those years—and Russia today. And not just similar in the broad strokes, but in the details: the gloating at the beginning, fading into an insistence that the army is being too soft.

This is just plainly illustrated by the news and the political talk throughout TV in the US, when the following was on Mainstream media:

Fox news Reporter:

"So I'm trusting the government. And then when you see Made-in-lable, made in France, made in France—which they're going to uncover a lot of that stuff, all right—it's going to be the fallout. This is going to be substantial."

Four years later the same person:

"{I} believe the Bush Administration has to stop being defensive about waging war. At this point, the new Iraqi government should declare martial law in areas controlled by insurgents. That means anyone can be arrested and shot on sight. Curfew. Saddam was able to control Iraq, as you know, and defeat insurgencies against him. The new Iraqi government can do the same."

The victim blaming

Tucker Carlson on 3/11/08:

"How could you salvage Iraq at this point? I don't know, it's beyond our control. I mean, if somehow the Iraqis decided to behave like human beings or something..."

The goofy Christian nationalism

"Lieutenant General William Boykin is in charge of tracking down top terror targets, but Boyin, an Evangelical Christian, says neither man is America's true enemy. The enemy is spiritual. It's called the principality of darkness, and the enemy is a guy called Satan."

They had the same obsession with European decadence

Lieutenant General William Boykin:

"The continent of Europe is dark. It's hopelessly lost, and it's going to get worse. Every expert will tell you that by the middle of this century, the continent of Europe will be an Islamic continent."

And, uh, they both had gay fascism

On O'Reilly Factor, the second-in-line to the presidency said:

"There is a gay and secular fascism in this country that wants to impose its will on the rest of us and is prepared to use violence."

Oh, and, um, incitement to genocide

Transcript from Fox News:

"We need to kill them. We need to kill. Think these people would act like savages—all coming from the Iraqi scum. And I'm going to say it like it is: the war we're fighting. In a sane world, every country would unite against Iran and blow it off the face of the earth. That would be the wealthy people. They are very depressed by the weakness that America is showing in the Muslim world. They say, 'Oh, there's a billion of them.' I said,

'So kill 100 million of them, then there'll be 900 million of them.' I mean, would you rather die? Would you rather us die than them? I mean, what is it going to take for your people to wake up? Because you're going to have to make that choice sooner rather than later."

When I was younger, I thought this was just what normal politics was. Then, when I grew up, I thought it was just an emotional reaction to a once-in-a-lifetime terror attack and that I'd never see it again. But now I see it every time I open any Twitter account. I can't think about [Vladimir Soloviev](#) without thinking about early Fox News. I can't see the same dimwitted indifference of regular Russians without thinking about the same dimwitted indifference of Americans or Europeans. And I can't see the cowardice of Russian liberals without seeing my own cowardice. This, of course, isn't a coincidence. Putin's political technologists don't get their ideas from the ether. Like all professionals, they look for best practices among their peers. And when Putin was first starting out, no one was more ahead of the curve than [Karl Rove](#) and [Roger Ailes](#).

But I think there's a deeper reason for the similarities, because fundamentally the invasion of Iraq and the invasion of Ukraine were fought with the same goal in mind—namely, destroying the liberal international order.

The main thing the neoconservative movement spent the '90s seething about was how Bill Clinton constantly insisted on coalition building and consensus.^[74] Clinton had waited until he had Yeltsin's permission to expand NATO. Clinton had waited until the other European countries were on board to intervene in Bosnia. Clinton had waited for French permission to intervene in Rwanda—permission which never came because the French were supporting the Huthis. Towards the tail end of his presidency, Clinton was less patient, but even in the Kosovo War the unilateral action was taken only after he spent two years begging for a multilateral effort, and only after he had gotten consensus with the French, Germans, British, and Italians.^[74-1]

The second move was to pass the American Service Members Protection Act, a law that preemptively authorized the president to invade the Netherlands in case any American was brought before the Hague.^[76] And the American voters ate it all up. But the problem is, there are people outside the US, and they noticed. In 2003 and 2004, they noticed that the US had gone completely insane. America's relationship with Europe collapsed.

The global South took it as proof that the US hadn't changed since the Vietnam era, and polls showed America became widely seen as the most dangerous country on Earth.^[77]

Countries in Which the U.S. is Viewed as the Greatest Threat*

	<u>U.S.</u>	<u>Second</u>	<u>Third</u>
Bangladesh	72	India 47	Pakistan 32
China	66	Japan 63	Taiwan 18
Turkey	64	Iraq 13	Russia 9
Pakistan	64	India 45	Israel 32
Indonesia	63	China 17	Russia 13
Venezuela	54	Iran 14	FARC 9**
Argentina	52	al Qaeda 8	Chile 8
Russia	49	Chechnya 29	al Qaeda 27
Malaysia	46	Abu Sayyaf 7	North Korea 6
Brazil	45	Iran 10	Venezuela 8
Bolivia	45	Chile 43	Venezuela 23
Mexico	44	Iran 25	China 20
Nigeria	32	Iran 14	China 12
Ukraine	31	al Qaeda 19	Iraq 14
Spain	29	al Qaeda 23	Iran 23
Morocco	17	Israel 15	Algeria 15
Senegal	15	Gambia 12	al Qaeda 8

* Where the U.S. is mentioned more frequently than any other country or group.

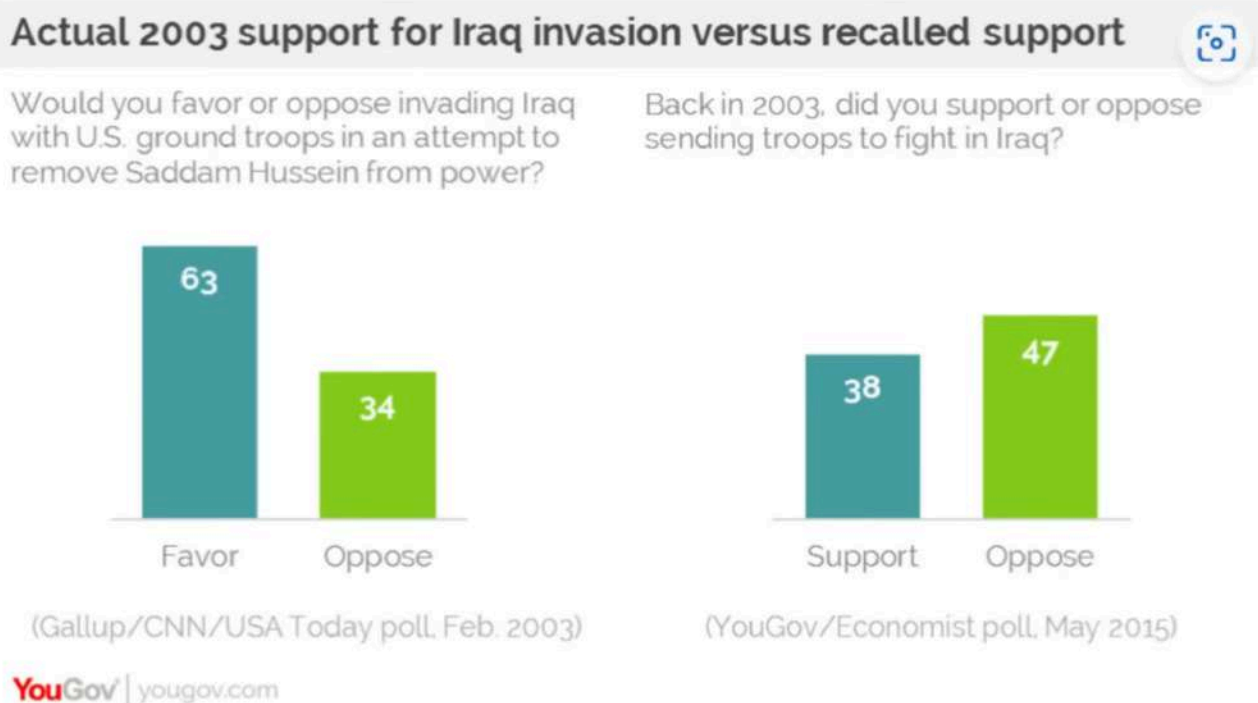
** Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia

Figures show the percent who mention each as a potential threat to their country.

In fact, in 2007 in Ukraine, yes, Ukrainian poll respondents said that the United States was the greatest threat to its national security—not Russia, the United States. But there's an important difference between America in the 2000s and Russia today: America was a democracy, which means Americans could just elect a new president, reverse course, and pretend it never happened. So from Clinton to Obama, change. And Obama said following his inauguration:

"...and even as we confront a vicious adversary that abides by no rules, I believe the United States of America must remain a standard bearer in the conduct of war. That is what makes us different from those whom we fight."

But the story can't end that tidily. People needed someone to blame, and they needed a way to distance themselves from the wars. In one sense, literally between 60 and 70% of the population supported the idea of invading Iraq before the war started, but years later, when Americans were asked to remember if they had supported the Iraq War back then, only about 30 to 40% say yes.^[78]



But there was a more subtle rewriting of history about why the Iraq War happened. A narrative was created that there were really two different types of Iraq War supporters: one was the innocent masses who were fooled into supporting the war through a massive propaganda campaign, and the other was the Deep State — meaning a sort of consortium of big business and defense agencies that created the propaganda.

The motive of the Deep State in the story varies with the telling. Sometimes it's some corporate moneyed interest (as per [Naomi Klein](#) in her book [The Shock Doctrine](#)), sometimes it's naïve idealism about spreading democracy (as per [Andrew Bacevich](#) via his book [The Age of Illusions](#)), and sometimes it's the Jews subordinating American interests to Israeli interests (as our beloved John J. Mearsheimer with [Stephen M. Walt](#) stated in their book [The Israel Lobby and U.S. Foreign Policy](#))^[79]

The motive isn't as important as the faith that there is a shadowy elite that tricked us, and that we would never have done something so stupid if not for them. In reality, the cause of the Iraq War is simpler: the American people are mostly racist, and they don't know enough geography to distinguish between places like Afghanistan, Pakistan, Iraq, or Saudi Arabia. So when 9/11 happened, they held this vague "brown people Muslim" racial category collectively responsible as the bad guys, and they demanded a policy of collective

punishment. Weak, sparsely populated Afghanistan just wasn't big enough to satisfy that urge.^[80]

To quote Henry Kissinger:

"After September 11th, the question for the United States has been how can we make it clear to **'the region'** that challenging the United States has disastrous country consequences, and therefore every government in **'the region'**, whether they were directly involved or not, must stop indirect support for these groups."

And so the Bush Administration picked the most convenient country to make an example of. That's why public opinion on the war never changed from the start of 2002 to the start of the war^[80-1], no matter how the media covered it. And that's how, voila, it sold it to Rumsfeld and Bush. Now, wars aren't monocausal, but that was the main cause—that was the oil that lubricated the gears of the war machine, not some secret plot. It was the politics of the lynch mob translated to foreign policy^[81]. And the foreign policy elite did not have any more sophisticated a view on this than the masses. I mean, here's the most influential liberal columnist in the country being asked the question: now that the war is over and there's some difficulty with the peace, was it worth doing?

I mean, here's [Thomas Friedman](#) the most influential liberal columnist in the country at the time being asked: *Now that the war is over and there's some difficulty with the peace, was it worth doing?*

"looking back I now certainly feel I understand more what the war was about out the terrorism bubble that basically built up over the 1990s said flying airplanes into the World Trade Center that's okay wrapping yourself with dynamite and blowing up Israelis in a pizza parlor that's okay because we're weak and they're strong and the weak have a different morality and having your press call people who do these kind of things Martyrs that's okay and that built up as a bubble Charlie and 9/11 to me was the peak of that bubble and what we learned on 911 in a gut way was that that bubble was a fundamental threat to our open society {...} and what we needed to do was go over to that part of the world I'm afraid and burst that bubble we needed to go over there basically uh take out a very big stick um right in the heart of of that world and um and burst that bubble {...} because part of that bubble said we've got you this bubble is actually going to level the balance of power between us and you because we don't care about life we're ready to sacrifice and all you care about are your stock options and your Hummers and what they needed to see was American boys and girls going house to house from Basra to Baghdad and basically saying which part of this sentence don't you understand you don't think you know we care uh about our open Society you think this bubble fantasy we just going to let it grow well suck on this that Charlie was what this war was about **we could have hit Saudi Arabia** it was part of that bubble, **we could have hit Pakistan** but **we hit Iraq because we could**"

Everyone kind of knows this in their gut, but getting away from the stark, ugly truth is the core motivation of the new populist foreign policy analysis—regardless of whether it's far-left populism, far-right populism, or whatever the hell the [Quincy Institute](#) is.

It's a version of events that flatters the prejudices of everyone. The left liked it because the left uncritically accepts any theory that tells them that the workers all secretly agree with them. The right liked it because, after the disaster, they needed a way to distance themselves from George Bush. And even the centrist pundits like the story because, I mean, isn't it a lot nicer to have everyone think you made an innocent mistake in the name of democracy rather than have them believe you joined in with a racist panic?

And six years later, the same columnist Thomas Friedman, as being asked the question on TV:

Are you upset with yourself about supporting that tactic and supporting that war?

“Yeah, I—my criticism of myself would be that, um, after 9/11, uh, **I overreacted**. Um, and I think as a country **we overreacted**. And at the same time, I do feel—and this was the argument on Iraq—that unless we found a way to collaborate with people in that part of the world to build a different kind of politics, to change the context in which people were able to: 1. grow up; 2. realize their aspirations; 3. live their lives, this problem was going to keep coming back, John, in one form or another.”

And so, everyone just sort of came to an agreement about how the Iraq War should be remembered: it was all the Deep State's fault, and they bore no responsibility regardless of whether or not they actually supported the war back then. There's just one small side effect of accepting this theory: it doesn't tell you what to do. It goes without saying that you can't trust the government or the experts, since they're the people who lied to you. But for most people, you can't really do your own research because, you know, you'd have to read books. So what do you do? Well, most people just put their head in the sand. But for a special few, they've blindly put their trust in a sort of self-made foreign policy counter-elite—and by counter-elite I, of course, mean **grifters**.

Chapter 2 (New York - 1970) Conspiracy

and let us start with one of the biggest grifter of all in US Politics: Lyndon LaRouche stating in TV:

"from 1946 until March 23rd 1983 the Strategic and foreign policies of the United States were steered by the influence of the most evil man of the 20th century the late Bertrand Russell"

In the 1970s as the country was shifting rapidly to the right and the radical left was cracking up the leader of One Small trotus sect had an idea the masses hated the new left but perhaps one could still build a winning leftwing Coalition by combining 1. extreme social conservatism with left-wing 2. economic populism and 3. extreme state-led developmentalism basically take everything that would appeal to a reactionary Building

Trades Union and then just bind it all together into a coherent ideology but how do you make all those ideas a coherent ideology? Well just **by creating an elaborate all-encompassing Conspiracy Theory of Everything**

Lyndon LaRouche again:

"I know of no case of any attack on me which has been published or which I have noticed in the news media which did not originate with either the drug Lobby or with the Soviet operation and sometimes the same thing"

this small extrus leader was named Lyndon LaRouche and his conspiracy theory is a little hard to summarize and it has changed a lot over the years but the core of it has remained consistent enough that I can summarize it somewhat so get ready for the Universum of LaRouchism, it goes like this:

the British royal family and a small Cadre of English Fabian socialists in conjunction with the Rockefellers and the Rothchilds are engaged in a conspiracy to greatly reduce the population of the human race in order to head off a malthusian catastrophe (as per the propaganda book found in: The population Bomb from Dr. Paul R. Ehrlich) a catastrophe that could easily be avoided by simply building a massive amount of nuclear power plants and a number of massive super highways and bridges to connect all of the world's continents but doing that would cut into the conspiracies profits so the British royal family invented environmentalism (as per: Silent spring by Rachal Carson) and neoliberalism (as per "Free to choose" by Milton and rose Friedman) in order to hide the truth and in order to further reduce the population the British royal family is also the world's foremost drug trafficking conspiracy and it uses its control of the IMF to push austerity in order to kill as many people in the global South as possible and also Henry Kissinger is a gay KGB agent.^[82]

All right, got it? That makes sense? Great!

Maybe some of that sounded reasonable to you. Well, that's how they get you. Because the LaRouche movement is really **a cult, not a political party**. It hooks in idealistic young people who like one aspect of the movement, indoctrinates them into the whole insane complex, and makes them work incredibly long hours for free—calling people up and begging for donations.

LaRouche used all the money he got from this phone call operation and ran for president every four years.^[83] And quoting him again, here's what he said in his real presidential campaign ad:

"Mondale is not simply a KGB agent in the ordinary sense. Of course, Mondale is jointly owned by the left wing of the Socialist International and the grain cartel interests. If both these owners told Mondale to lick the floor before a nationwide TV audience, I sincerely believe he would do just that."

These campaigns brought LaRouche to national prominence, and soon he was invited onto mainstream media to explain himself—with hilarious results:

News excerpt:

“He’s run for president three times, twice as a Democrat. Each time he’s lost overwhelmingly, but he’s not deterred by that.”

Another news clip:

“The Democratic National Committee responded with a 50-state alert aimed at preventing more nominations of LaRouche-backed candidates pretending to be regular Democrats. The LaRouchians, calling themselves the National Democratic Policy Committee, claimed to have 800 candidates running in primaries around the country this year.”

Reporter: “What are you trying to do, running hundreds of candidates all over the country? What is your short-term goal?”

LaRouche: “I’m concerned with two things: I’m concerned with the collapse of Western civilization.” (and yes he really ended his sentence then)

Follow-up question: “Were you ever a Marxist, in your own opinion? Yes or no?”

LaRouche: “I don’t know. I don’t know.”

News reporter: “Mr. LaRouche, I want to quote you back to yourself. This is something I read on your stationary, written by you: ‘According to authoritative sources, Henry Kissinger—that’s our former Secretary of State—is not a Jew but a faggot. He is of the species some psychopathologists describe as an extreme anal variety of sadomasochistic personality.’ Has any psychopathologist ever suggested to you that you ought to be locked up?”

In America, LaRouche became something of a joke—even *The Simpsons* made an [episode](#) parodying him.

But around the world, LaRouche was building another source of power. He reinvented himself as an intelligence dealer, publishing a weekly magazine called *Executive Intelligence Review* (EIR). Using his network of intelligence contacts, the magazine claimed to reveal “what was really going on” behind the scenes. By the early 1980s, LaRouche was taking meetings with CIA officials—but he was also under FBI investigation. It didn’t take long for the FBI to uncover that the LaRouche organization was involved in credit card fraud, charging people without their consent.^[84]

LaRouche’s influence in American intelligence was somewhat limited, he appears to have been useful to the CIA as a source about what the South African Intelligence agencies were up to in Angola, since LaRouche was working for South African intelligence spying on and attacking anti-apartheid groups in America. His influence in 1990s Russia is also attested to by a story found in Donald Rumsfeld memoirs, where Rumsfeld complains that he had to spend 20 minutes convincing the Russian general staff that LaRouche had not been the mastermind of Reagan’s Strategic Defense Initiative (SDI) program.

Now that LaRouche could no longer live in America, he moved to Germany to live with his second wife, Helga Zepp-LaRouche. There, he founded a new organization called the [International Schiller Institute](#) and began forming connections in various European countries, including Russia—a country he had previously tried to blame for all kinds of conspiracies. He once said:

"Russians are irrationalists, they're racists—Russian racists. If you don't believe it, ask the Ukrainians."

He continued publishing his intelligence magazine in Europe and added a few new writers to his roster. The most important among them was [William Engdahl](#), who was also peddling conspiratorial nonsense. For example, Engdahl claimed:

"The Greek crisis was programmed to be detonated at command by Wall Street and the U.S. Treasury, as well as the Federal Reserve, in order to defend the reserve currency role of the U.S. dollar."

You probably haven't heard of William Engdahl, but you might recognize some of the conspiracy theories he has invented—most notably, the claim that Bill Gates is trying to sterilize the human race using vaccines. Engdahl first spread this theory in 2009^[85]. But that's not even his most significant theory.

In the 1990s, *Executive Intelligence Review* started focusing obsessively on a Jewish hedge fund manager named [George Soros](#). This obsession culminated in an article by Engdahl alleging that Soros was secretly using a small network of NGOs to overthrow governments on behalf of the Rothschilds. According to Engdahl, Soros caused all the revolutions of 1989 that toppled Communist states in Eastern Europe, allegedly to introduce "shock therapy" and destroy them.

This theory didn't make much of a splash at the time and might have been forgotten altogether if not for a movement developing on the American left^[86]. A small subsection of the left—driven by complex reasons that are too detailed to fully unpack here—became obsessed with proving the innocence of Serbian dictator [Slobodan Milošević](#).

If you want the full picture, you can look up works like [Yugoslavia: Peace, War, and Dissolution](#) by Naomi Choms, [To Kill a Nation: The Attack on Yugoslavia](#) by [Michael Parenti](#), and [The Politics of Genocide](#) by [Edward S. Herman](#) and [David Peterson](#).

This section of the left was naturally caught off guard when, following a clumsy attempt to rig the 2000 election^[87], Slobodan Milošević chose to step down amid massive protests. Almost immediately afterward, he was handed over to The Hague for prosecution—an outcome that even many of his Western opponents had long since given up on.

This section of the left was naturally distraught and quickly latched onto the theory originally created by the LaRouche movement—that George Soros had orchestrated the overthrow of Milošević^[88], just as he had allegedly orchestrated the fall of the Eastern European

communist regimes. However, since this theory was now appearing in left-wing publications, Soros's role shifted from being a tool of the Rothschilds to being an agent of the CIA.

One of the prominent writers contributing to these left-wing outlets was a Canadian economist named [Michel Chossudovsky](#), who went on to create his own publication—likely because other magazines wouldn't publish his controversial 9/11 “truth” articles. His book, [War and Globalization: The Truth Behind September 11](#)^[89], became a key text for this wing of conspiracy discourse.

Michel Chossudovsky quickly hired William Engdahl along with a raft of other conspiracy theorists to publish through his think tank, the Center for Research on Globalization (CRG), better known as [Global Research](#). This website would later form a lucrative partnership with the Russian government. Global Research offers audiences a wide range of conspiracy theories, many of which align closely with narratives favored by Russian state media and experts consider Kremlin-influenced disinformation.

For example, during the COVID-19 pandemic, Chossudovsky appeared on his [YouTube channel, GRTV](#), claiming:

“Depicting COVID-19 as a dangerous virus—that's the basis of the fear campaign.”

Chossudovsky, the site's listed editor and a retired professor, has refused to answer questions about any direct links to Russia but has denied that Global Research operates as a Kremlin-aligned disinformation platform.

But hold on, we're getting ahead of ourselves. Let's cut back to 2003 in Georgia, where President [Eduard Shevardnadze](#) (in office from 1995 to 2003) was being ousted by his own protégé, [Mikheil Saakashvili](#) (president from 2004 to 2013). This didn't make many waves in Russia, mainly because Putin despised Shevardnadze and was glad to see him go. Many Russians perceived the event—known as the [Rose Revolution](#) (November 3 to November 23, 2003)—as a welcome change.

However, it caught the attention of some Western observers because several of the NGOs involved in pushing out Shevardnadze had been funded by George Soros^[90]. Suddenly, the old Slobodan Milošević theory—claiming Soros engineered regime changes—seemed vindicated^[91].

LaRouche accused George Soros of working for the Rockefellers, the left accused Soros of working for the CIA, and even neoconservatives at *The Weekly Standard* accused Soros of supporting Saakashvili to undermine George Bush, since Eduard Shevardnadze had been such a reliable American ally. However, none of this theorizing gained traction in Russia until a year later, when something happened in Ukraine^[92].

Chapter 3 (Kyiv, 2004: The Orange Revolution)

In the early 2000s, [Gleb Pavlovsky](#) was Russia's most influential political technologist. He had been the chief architect of Putin's public image since Yeltsin chose Putin as his successor^[93]. By 2004, Pavlovsky was tasked with a \$600 million budget to ensure Viktor Yanukovych's victory in the Ukrainian presidential election.

His campaign used familiar themes: portraying the opposition as Nazis, warning that they would divide the country, ban the Russian language, and outlaw the Orthodox Church. But despite these efforts, Yanukovych lost.

Returning to Russia, Pavlovsky needed an excuse to explain this failure—and conveniently, there was already one waiting for him, courtesy of the West: the conspiracy theories promoted by Michel Chossudovsky and William Engdahl.

Pavlovsky proclaimed to audiences back in Russia that the 2000 overthrow of Slobodan Milošević^[94] and the 2003 ousting of Eduard Shevardnadze had, like the Orange Revolution, been orchestrated by the West using secret technologies and tactics developed by the CIA. The playbook? Small youth groups performing theatrical protest pieces combined with mass demonstrations^[94-1].

In the late 1990s, a Serbian protest group called [Otpor!](#) emerged, led by [Srdja Popovic](#). Otpor! organized numerous anti-government protests characterized by a comic, theatrical edge. Not coincidentally, Milošević was toppled in 2000 after attempting to rig his re-election^[95]. This success made Otpor! leaders into celebrities, and Popovic became a sought-after consultant on anti-dictator protests. Popovic credited one of the key influences behind Otpor!'s methods: [From Dictatorship to Democracy](#) by [Gene Sharp](#), an American pacifist who developed a theory of nonviolent revolution^[95-1].

About a year later, it was revealed that Otpor! had received several million dollars from the [National Endowment for Democracy \(NED\)](#), a small NGO founded by the U.S. Congress during the Reagan Administration to give a more palatable face to Reagan's aggressive foreign policy^[96].

Ironically, the funding of Otpor! and similar groups was championed in America by some anti-war activists—like Martin Sheen, who made the movie *Bringing Down a Dictator*—who hoped to show that Clinton's decision to bomb Serbia was not only unnecessary but counterproductive. They argued that pacifist methods like Otpor!'s nonviolent resistance would have worked better.

As the U.S. media hyped up their own exaggerated role in the [Bulldozer Revolution](#), Pavlovsky had a new idea: maybe the CIA was behind training these government-overthrow “performance art” youth groups across Eastern Europe. The theory went that Gene Sharp was the mastermind, Srdja Popovic a frontman, and George Soros along with the National Endowment for Democracy served as the funding mechanisms. Through this network, the CIA had overthrown Milosevic, Shevardnadze, and was now targeting Viktor Yanukovych.

By early 2005, when the [Tulip Revolution](#) toppled the government in Kyrgyzstan, Pavlovsky claimed it was part of the same Western-backed playbook. According to him, Moldova, Belarus, and even Russia itself were the next countries in line^[96-1] and so Putin should give him more money to create a sort of preventive counterrevolution. These four revolutions Pavlovsky is talking about—Bulldozer Revolution, the Rose Revolution, the Tulip Revolution, and the Orange Revolution—came to be known as the Color Revolutions. Now you might ask why is it that only one of them is named after a color. The fact that they're called Color Revolutions actually turns out to be a telling clue of why so many people will latch onto an anti-Semitic red-brown conspiracy theory invented by a cult and adopted opportunistically by a dictator.^[97]

And the same time as the Orange Revolution (November 23, 2004), Bush's war in Iraq (Second Battle of Fallujah on November 7th, 2004) was spinning out of control into a bloodbath. So Bush tried to salvage the reputation of his Middle East policy by tying it to the idea of democracy promotion. Bush stated at the Bratislava Conference in 2005:

"In recent times we have witnessed landmark events in the history of liberty: a Rose Revolution in Georgia, an Orange Revolution in Ukraine, and now a Purple Revolution in Iraq."

The Iraq War had never really been about Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMDs) or terrorism; it had been about democracy. And since Iraq was about democracy promotion, in a sense it had been the inspiration for the revolutions in Eastern Europe and Central Asia. So when you think about it, really the Iraq War was a success—even as the country slipped into civil war—because the war had sent democracy vibes to Ukraine... Yep, that's how it is told.

Soon Bush's cheerleaders in the media even started calling the Iraqi elections the Purple Revolution to match with the Orange Revolution, and so the name Color Revolution stuck.

^[98] There was only one person on Earth who could have fallen for this spin—unfortunately, that man was also in Bratislava—and it was Putin, who the next day stated:

"We're not going to try to invent a special Russian democracy. But our democratic institutions should be appropriate to Russia's circumstances today, to our history and our traditions."

Putin, who immediately became convinced that Pavlovsky was right and that Bush must be angling to overthrow him, put his political technologist to work trying to prevent one.^[99] To that end, the Russian government started making contacts with the conspiracy theorists at Global Research, including William Engdahl, who in turn wrote a book called [Full Spectrum Dominance: Totalitarian Democracy in the New World Order](#). This book synthesized the LaRouche conspiracy theory of revolutions (see *EIR Executive Intelligence Review*) with the pro-Milošević conspiracy theory of revolutions and the Kremlin's theory of revolutions by Gleb Pavlovsky^[100] into one almost coherent narrative. That narrative goes something like this, are you ready:

A formless, unknowable deep state **Them**: (be it Raytheon, Jews, Pentagon, CIA, QAnon, Fabian Society, Lockheed Martin, MI6, Royal Family of England, or just freaking Reptilians) in the American government, using the Bush Administration, the National Endowment for Democracy, George Soros, Srdja Popović, Gene Sharp, and USAID, has the ability to create mass protests on demand and is using this power to overthrow every government in Eurasia that's standing in the way of America's ambition to monopolize control over Central Asian oil pipelines—namely, the critical Baku-Tbilisi-Ceyhan pipeline (BTC Pipeline).^[101]



If any of that sounds familiar, it's because he basically just replaced the British royal family from the LaRouche theory with the villain plot from James Bond's *The World Is Not Enough*.

That moment marks the globalization of the "color revolution" conspiracy theory. The first country to pick it up from Russia was Venezuela, with Hugo Chávez eagerly adopting the narrative to explain away anti-government protests and frame them as U.S.-engineered coups. The second was Iran, which took it a step further—producing a *bizarrely surreal propaganda video* featuring NPC-like animated figures modeled after characters from Sonic 06, including cameos by George Soros and John McCain.

You can see it for yourself here: [Iranian Propaganda Video featuring John McCain, George Soros – YouTube](#).

Seriously—it's unintentionally hilarious and worth watching just for the sheer absurdity.^[102]

So let's pause and actually ask: is the Color Revolution theory true? Well—no, not really. And there are some pretty big holes you can poke in it right away. For one, Popović's group (Otpor) wasn't the magic key to overthrowing Slobodan Milošević. They had been organizing protests and campaigns in Serbia for years with *very little success*. If they were part of some elite CIA psychological operation, it sure wasn't working.

What actually changed in 2000 was:

(A) The trade unions—particularly in the provinces—who had previously supported Milošević, finally turned against him due to worsening economic and political conditions.

(B) Bill Clinton had recently traveled to Russia, where he urged the newly elected Vladimir Putin to apply pressure on Milošević to step down—meaning even Russia was signaling it was done with him.

The President: Yeah, is he afraid to leave office? (Q)

President Putin: I think I can have a word with him and relate to him that the international community will not hold this against him and there will be no action against him. But I would like to discuss this further and think this needs to be explained to him again. (Q)

The President: But would he be able to stay in Serbia? Would they let him go somewhere else? (Q)

President Putin: I think it would be better if he stays in Serbia. (Q)

The President: Yeah, me too, but I just don't know what the climate is there. (Q)

President Putin: Frankly, I don't know, of course, but maybe he would want to leave. It's a possible move on his part, but I don't know. We don't want such a gift. Why don't we send him to America? (Q)

The President: Yes, I know what you mean. Let me think about this. The only thing I'm worried about is that later on we don't want to look like we were duped into helping him steal the

(C) The massive Western sanctions campaign against Serbia had reached a breaking point, crippling the economy and causing widespread unrest, especially outside of Belgrade. [103]

In other words, Milošević wasn't overthrown because of some masterclass in protest theory funded by George Soros—it was because his base collapsed, his allies abandoned him, and his economy fell apart. The color revolution theory conveniently skips all of that to paint a cartoonishly simple and conspiratorial picture.

But, problem one: the Rose and Orange Revolutions weren't really revolutions at all. Sure, the mass protests helped put pressure on their respective dictators, but ultimately both crises were resolved by backroom deals between political elites [32-4]. Problem two was the lack of motivation — Saakashvili and Shevardnadze just didn't have very different foreign policies [104]. Problem three is that color revolutions only happen to corrupt democracies. Regular dictators can fare them just fine — you just throw all the protesters in jail and ban the NGO, which makes them pretty useless for regime change since they can pretty much only hit leaders who don't have a consolidated regime [105]. Problem four is that the amount of money actually being given to these NGOs by the National Endowment for Democracy is usually in the mid six-figure range, which is enough for, like, two staff salaries and an office space — and they're operating in countries where every TV station is controlled by the government. [106]

So, aside from the fact that there was no motive for America in half of these countries, the fact that half of them involved leaders voluntarily stepping down, and the fact that the idea that you can overthrow a government on a \$2 million budget is just an inherently silly idea, that is ever more clear with a simple question: Who would win? The combined military and police forces of a brutal dictatorship, or the CIA handing out \$15 per protester?

It's probably no surprise the color revolutions Putin dreaded just never came. Putin's real problem was succession^[107]. Russia had term limits, which meant Putin would either have to alter the Constitution or step down. So he stepped down and chose a handpicked weak successor named Dmitri Medvedev (President of Russia 2008–2012), and just like Yeltsin had done for Putin, Putin started a war in the Caucasus and let Medvedev lead it so he could look like a hero — so came the Russo-Georgian War or [South Ossetia War](#), 2008.

And this worked. Russia had a peaceful transition of power with no color revolutions, and relations with the West even warmed up — maybe a little too fast, given he had just blown up a sovereign country. But otherwise, things seemed to be going well, and in Russia, fears of a color revolution started to fade. But the theory about color revolutions found a new champion in America.

In 2004, George Soros had become the target of a massive smear campaign from the neoconservative movement after he had publicly opposed the Iraq War and donated a large sum of money to John Kerry's campaign. ^[108]

This produced a book called [The Shadow Party](#) by David Horowitz and Richard Poe, in which they talked about how George Soros had caused every world revolution in the past 20 years and how he was now coming for America. And you'll never guess who their source was (yes, it was completely founded on the nonsense spewed by William Engdahl). This book then inspired a 2-hour long TV segment by Fox News, in which the following was said on TV:^[108-1]

“Soros has helped fund the Velvet (purple) Revolution in the Czech Republic, the orange revolution in Ukraine, the rose revolution in Georgia.”

The text is almost verbatim from what you could see in Russian propaganda a few years later, that goes like this:^[109]

- (1) Step one: you form a shadow government. He's done that — infiltrate the target country using humanitarian aid.
- (2) You control the airwaves — this is his media empire.
- (3) You cause a political or economic crisis or you take advantage of an existing crisis.
- (4) You wait for an election and then you cry voter fraud.
- (5) Stage five: massive demonstrations and you accuse opponents of voter fraud through radio and TV stations that you control.

Now I should make clear for non-American readers: this man, who repeatedly said those words above and propagated the nonsense of *The Shadow Party* book, had the highest

rated cable news show in 2010. He was widely considered the single most influential pundit in America — this is despite the fact that, you know, Glenn Beck the presenter of Fox News is insane^[110]. And now he was making Color Revolution theory mainstream just in time for the Arab Spring.

Chapter 4 (cario - 2011) The arab spring

Glenn Beck stated on Fox News at the O'Reilly Factor^[110-1]:

"When we started to do our homework on this, we found that the, um, State Department has worked with, uh, with Google and youth groups. State Department want to accomplish through Google the revolution in Egypt — that's what they were working on, the revolution. They wanted Mubarak out of there, yes."

Beck was convinced that a shadowy cabal of American Fabian socialists had used their control of Google to overthrow the Egyptian government... somehow... Glenn continued on his Fox show:

"It is not pro-democracy. Now maybe it maybe it is for some. I mean, the people have been abused by a brutal dictator — that is true — and I stand with the people of Egypt, but they're being played."

And Glenn Beck was not alone. According to basically any official in the State Department who has ever had to mediate between Obama and Putin, Vladimir Putin is 100% convinced that the Arab Spring was organized by Obama and the CIA as a color Revolution. Take the words of Ambassador to the Russian Federation (2005–2008), Deputy Secretary of State (2011–2014), and CIA Director (2021–2025) William J. Burns^[111]:

"For Putin, um, the Arab Spring and the revolutions and upheavals that unfolded from the beginning of 2011 on were of a piece with the color Revolutions in the former Soviet Union."

Or from Jake Sullivan, the vice presidential national security advisor (2013–2016) and National Security Advisor (2017–2025)^[111-1]:

"The Arab Spring which had increased his paranoia about America's role in fomenting revolution abroad."

Still not enough: here's Ben Rhodes, who was deputy National Security Advisor (2009–2017) and podcaster ever since^[111-2]:

"I was on lots of these phone calls with Obama and Putin in the late Obama years where Putin would always say that your policy [is] regime change and Obama would be like no it's not. And Putin believes, or at least says that he believes, that US policy is regime change, and he said that for a very long time. He accused Hillary Clinton of trying to

topple his government in 2012 because she issued a written statement, I think, about the parliamentary elections.”

Furthermore, Daniel Fried (the Assistant Secretary of State 2005–2009), when asked about Putin’s belief in color revolutions, responded:^[111-3]

“Like man, we are not that good, we are not that good. I even told Russian television once, when they were accusing me personally of being the ‘gray cardinal’ of the color revolutions, I said: I wish! How come you see America with a massive budget being unable to do much to stop the political deterioration and security deterioration in Iraq and you think, on no budget at all, we can overthrow Moscow-supported governments in Kyiv and Tbilisi? Are you kidding me? But they really thought we were doing.”

It’s hard to say who convinced Putin of this, but it’s worth noting all the conspiracy theorists at Global Research I was talking about earlier had already gotten jobs with the Russian government by the time the Arab Spring had started, and many of them were already working at Russian-funded think tanks with people like Alexander Dugin.^[112]

We know for sure one person who didn’t convince Putin of this theory, though, is Dmitri Medvedev, because Medvedev had given Obama permission to start the war in Libya—a decision that infuriated Putin and convinced him Medvedev couldn’t be trusted with running the government anymore. So they had a little private chat^[113], and suddenly Medvedev had something to announce in 2011 at the National Congress in Moscow:

"This congress should support the candidacy of Vladimir Putin to be President of Russia."

And this is where things all start to go downhill. Prime Minister Putin announced he would run for a third term as president next year, switching jobs yet again with the current president Dmitri Medvedev. In response, Finance Minister Alexei Kudrin resigned, and criticism swelled on Russian internet sites. Then Putin was booed by spectators at a martial arts event in Moscow—a rare display of public disapproval.

Because Russia’s stability hadn’t been built on some magical propaganda technique, it had been built on a belief among a large number of Russians that Russia was basically moving in the right direction towards the West. The country might not have been a democracy, but it was getting there—just at its own pace. Putin’s return felt like a step backwards, and Putin, by stepping down in the first place, had punctured the myth of his own indispensability. So, when the government was caught defrauding the parliamentary elections that same year, people used it as an opportunity to have their say. This video posted on YouTube reportedly showed ballots that had been filled out ahead of the actual voting. Anger boiled into the streets last week with several protests that brought a heavy show of force by police and large numbers of arrests. These protests were mostly ignored in the West, and even when the media did pay attention, they were more than a little dismissive.

No one in the West saw the makings of a revolution, but Putin did. He was sure the color revolution had come for him. Even worse, he became convinced that the moderates in his administration, including Medvedev, were in on it. So history would have to be rewritten.

State TV ran a documentary exposé in which Russian generals confessed that in 2008 Dmitri Medvedev had been a massive coward and had in fact almost botched and lost the war with Georgia somehow, and that the war was only saved by secret orders issued by Vladimir Putin behind the scenes. Then Putin fired all his moderate advisers and surrounded himself with his old KGB friends, and filled a bunch of cabinet posts with wacky far-right nationalists. Then he created a mass paramilitary force answerable directly to him and run by his own personal security guard^[114].

Putin also radically changed his approach to domestic politics. Instead of depicting himself as the man who brought law and order to Russia and allowed it to modernize, Putin made modernity itself the enemy. He was now the defender of traditional values against modernity, which was now an artificial American construct^[115], and that the attempt to modernize Russia forced on it by the Americans is what had caused the chaos of the '90s. This idea about what caused the '90s might seem like a small abstract distinction, but it actually changed a lot. Putin had turned the '90s from something bad in Russia's past into an ever-present threat—something America was chomping at the bit to impose on Russia and would again if not for Vladimir Putin. The country was now on a permanent Cold War footing, but it would take several years for America to notice.

This also rewrote Russia's relationship with Europe (think German friend of Putin Gerhard Schröder). Before the protests, Putin saw the EU as an opportunity to pry Europe away from America, especially during the Bush years, but Obama had repaired the relationship with Europe to such an extent that it seemed hopeless^[116]. The EU, like the State Department, had been mildly critical of Russia for rigging its elections, so the EU was written off as an irredeemable puppet of the United States. This was a big problem for a certain president of Ukraine.

Victor Yanukovich had built his entire foreign policy around pushing America away and pulling Europe closer as a way of balancing between East and West, but now suddenly Russia decides Europe is the enemy^[117]. Now Yanukovich has no way to balance between the demands of his people and the demands of the Kremlin. Maybe something could have been worked out if Russia's policy towards Ukraine had been handled by a deft diplomatic hand; instead, it was being handled by this man: [Sergei Glazyev](#), back then Chairman of the Economic Policy Committee of the State Duma of the Russian Federation.

Sergei Glazyev started out in the early '90s as a reformist economist for Boris Yeltsin, but after being pushed out on corruption charges, he went crazy and became an anti-Semitic ultra-nationalist. In 2004, he was put in charge of the far-right party Rodina. Then, when Putin purged the government of Medvedev supporters in 2011, he was brought into the

government proper^[118]. One other fun fact about Sergei Glazyev: that he believed and stated on national TV:

“This year, progressive people around the world are observing the centenary of the birth of the brilliant thinker and I wouldn’t hesitate to say prophet of our time, Lyndon LaRouche.”

He is the leading member of the Lyndon LaRouche movement in Russia. Through the LaRouche organization, he made his name as a nationalist politician by publishing a book accusing the same Anglo-Jewish conspiracy of intentionally causing a genocide in Russia^[119].

And Putin had put him in charge of Eurasian immigration — that is to say, creating an alternative to the EU and getting Ukraine into it. This meant that Russia's relationship with Ukraine was in the hands of a man who believes genocidal Jewish bankers run the EU. So as Yanukovich negotiated with Europe, Glazyev became the face of the movement to keep Ukraine out of the EU, making regular appearances on Ukrainian TV and at conferences. It was Glazyev who threatened Ukraine with war even before the Euromaidan started, and it was Glazyev who wrote most of the propaganda script that Russian media would use in response to the protests — that pro-European Ukrainians were in fact all gay Nazi CIA agents.

This all pushed the Ukrainian people even more towards Europe. By January, Yanukovich was trapped. He had tried to break up the protest with force and they got bigger. He had the Russians breathing down his neck, telling him to use more force or else they would take back their \$15 billion. He also had Joe Biden in his office telling him that if he did shoot protesters, America would sanction the hell out of the country. So he tries to make a deal^[120]: if the opposition helps quell the protesters, he'll give two of the opposition leaders ministerial portfolios. The opposition is skeptical of this offer, so they take it to the American Embassy and ask for advice, and the Americans tell them to take the deal — but with one condition.

And here’s probably the moment some of you are waiting for — the Nuland phone call. So what’s going on here? [Victoria Nuland](#), the Deputy Secretary of State, probably correctly thinks this offer is a trap. Nuland doesn’t want Vitali Klitschko (the former heavyweight wrestler) to go into the government because if both Arseniy Yatsenyuk (the technocrat in Ukraine) and Vitali Klitschko went into the government at the same time, that would leave only Oleh Tyahnybok — who you will recall from earlier is a Nazi — out on the street.

Leaving Tyahnybok on the street would turn him into the sole face of the movement^[120-1], which would radicalize it and scare off the normies. Now, that would reduce the movement’s mass appeal but would also dangerously polarize the country even more — a risk Yanukovich was willing to take because he saw it as the only way to keep himself in power.

Now, Arseniy Yatsenyuk had experience dealing with Yanukovich as his foreign minister, so he was the most likely to survive any sort of bureaucratic warfare that Yanukovich would

engage against him. Klitschko had zero political experience, so Nuland wanted Klitschko to swallow his pride and stay on the street.^[121]

Arseniy Yatsenyuk and Klitschko instead rejected Nuland's idea and just scrapped the deal altogether, so the violence continued. Now, of course, the reason we know this is because the phone call was recorded by the FSB and leaked^[121-1]. But the fact that the phone call was leaked tells us something else very important: the Kremlin was more afraid of Yanukovich making a deal with the opposition than it was of Yanukovich being overthrown. After all, why else try to scuttle a deal that would have kept Yanukovich in power unless they were already convinced Yanukovich was going to backstab them?

Now, this might be why the Kremlin wasn't just in contact with Yanukovich but also directly in contact with Yanukovich's underlings. Either way, it was clear Yanukovich didn't control his security services.

His interior minister (Vitaliy Zakharchenko, Minister of Interior, 2012–2014), the chief of all federal law enforcement, had ghosted him and was not answering his calls. All his lieutenants had disappeared with him, so the marooned police forces in the middle of the protest just had to surrender in exchange for safe passage out of the city. This left Yanukovich with no police force loyal to him left in the entire capital. So naturally, Yanukovich made a run for it (leaving Kyiv in a helicopter and disappearing for a while).^[122]

And we all know how Russia responded. Russian President Vladimir Putin made his first visit since Russia annexed Crimea from Ukraine. After taking Crimea, Russia knew they had lit the fuse on a divided, unstable Ukraine, so all they had to do was wait for Ukraine to dissolve into a civil war so that they could move in and mop it up. So they waited and waited and waited, and when there weren't any uprisings, Glazyev tried to organize them.^[123] For six weeks, Glazyev paid protesters to attack government buildings and stir up riots, but the central government simply ignored them—and so did most of the locals. The civil war and breakup of Ukraine was just not going to happen on its own.

This perhaps should have been a sign that color revolution theory was wrong, and you cannot in fact overthrow a government by giving a few thousand dollars to NGOs. After all, Russia had followed all the steps it had accused America of following precisely: it paid protesters, it sent agent provocateurs, it sent mobs to take over government buildings, it engaged in street theater, it broadcast fake news about how the Banderites were coming to kill everyone—and normal life just hummed along.^[123-1]

Instead, Glazyev took it as a sign that the “gay Anglo-Jewish Nazi CIA” was working even harder behind the scenes to keep Ukraine stable. After all, he had that phone call from Nuland, Secretary of State US—look, she said “Yatsenyuk is the guy,” and Yatsenyuk did get appointed prime minister for the interim government. I mean, what are the chances of that happening coincidentally? How often does the leader of the biggest opposition party gain power after the opposition party takes control of the government? Had to be the CIA... Noooo, no shit Sherlock.

But this cycle of escalation in response to an imaginary American escalation would continue into August, by which point hundreds of people would be dead. At the same time Glazyev was trying to organize a color revolution, the Russian Ministry of Defense was putting out a massive PR campaign. On the 3rd Moscow Conference on International Security in 2014, Russia's defense establishment holds a conference each year to discuss the most pressing security issues that face the region. This year's conference was originally scheduled to focus on what would happen in Central Asia once the United States withdraws from Afghanistan, but Defense Minister [Sergei Shoigu](#) changed all that with an opening speech in which he said that major threats to peace today are the so-called color revolutions.

According to this view, color revolutions would include the Arab Spring revolts in Egypt, Libya, and Syria—and of course the latest revolution in Ukraine.^[124]

Putin rebranded himself one more time. Instead of being a protector of Russia from American aggression, he was a global Messiah sent to protect the whole world from Barack Obama's massive global regime change rampage, which at this point in his estimation had caused wars in Libya, Egypt, Tunisia, Syria, Yemen, and now Ukraine.^[125]



And here Russia found astronomical success. Both the left-wing press and the right-wing press in the West followed Russia's lead—not just fringe publications either. This time, mainstream publications, respected international relations scholars (California profs like John Mearsheimer), Harvard economists, rock stars, lots of people were eager to rewrite history (like Chossudovsky) to make the Arab Spring and the Ukraine war a CIA operation. All this becomes apparent when we again examine the lectures of international relations expert John Mearsheimer. He states:

“The third part of the story is fostering an Orange Revolution. This is all about promoting democracy. As you all know, the United States runs around the world trying to topple regimes and put in their place democratically elected regimes. Globalists, Zionists, the European Union—they're not in the least bit interested in Ukrainian freedom. They're

interested in using Ukrainian nationalism as a way of attacking Russia. And it's Libya that no longer has a strong man who, in his own small way, was actually willing to challenge the Washington Consensus."

And who better to push your theory that the Euromaidan was run by gay Nazi CIA agents than the famous Hollywood movie director who won two Oscars for his movie about how JFK was murdered by gay Nazi CIA agents?[125-1] Soon, dedicated journalism outfits were created specifically to prove everything was a color revolution: the protests in Belarus, the protests in Kazakhstan, the Chinese blame protests in Hong Kong on it. YouTubers call small LGBT protests in Vietnam color revolutions. Anti-royalist protests in Thailand are called color revolutions. Hungary accused George Soros of leading a Jewish plot to destroy Christian values in Europe through color revolutions.[125-2]



And Israel joined in, accusing George Soros of leading an anti-Semitic plot to destroy Israeli values through color revolutions.[125-3]

And in 2020, we hit peak insanity with an accusation from William Engdahl himself that the [George Floyd protests](#) were a color revolution fomented by the American government to overthrow itself[126]. (I wish I was, but im NOT making it up)

As the years went on, more and more people became convinced of the theory that the CIA and George Soros had organized every protest in the world since 1989. I once saw someone call the 1905 Russian Revolution a color revolution (and I'm still not joking)[126-1].



Russia's propaganda campaign on this front has been so successful that Washington began treating it as a national security threat, desperately trying to pin down the alchemy that made it work. The 2016 election when Trump was elected only made that paranoia ten times worse. But Russia's influence on this front wouldn't stop growing until February 2022, when they finally told a lie too big to ignore — when the Russian war with Ukraine began.

Back in 2014, Americans weren't really paying attention to Ukraine. The real target of the anti-Ukrainian propaganda campaign was Europe, where Russia made major breakthroughs. This was a problem for Barack Obama because his strategy for punishing Russia relied on using Europe to put economic pressure on Russia — and Europe wasn't obliging. So Obama went to Brussels and gave a big speech trying to convince the Europeans that maybe it would be a good idea for them to care about European security. His speech was surprisingly good; quote:^[127]

“To be honest, if we define our interests narrowly, if we applied a cold-hearted calculus, we might decide to look the other way. Our economy is not deeply integrated with Ukraine's; our people and our homeland face no direct threat from the invasion of Crimea; our own borders are not threatened by Russia's annexation. But that kind of casual indifference would ignore the lessons that are written in the cemeteries of this continent.”

He also, in a moment that surely went over most people's heads, made a point of explicitly denying Color Revolution Theory:

“It's not America that filled the Maidan with protesters — it was Ukrainians. No foreign forces compelled the citizens of Tunis and Tripoli to rise up; they did so on their own.”

As Obama continued:

“Do not think for a moment that your own freedom, your own prosperity, that your own moral imagination is bound by the limits of your community, your ethnicity, or even your country — you’re bigger than that.”

Of course, it didn’t work. Just a few days later:



So Obama decided to settle—not for rolling back Russia entirely—but instead making an example out of them: setting the precedent that maybe America wouldn’t bomb you if you invaded your neighbor, but they would make sure you suffered at least a massive recession. The hope was that this economic punishment would be enough deterrence for everyone else.

Russia started running into problems by July. You see, the problem with hybrid warfare—as Russia’s tactics came to be known—is that it’s basically a reenactment of a conspiracy theory that only exists in fantasy. So, the tactics didn’t actually work. By August, the Ukrainian army was on the verge of winning the war. Putin, now caught in the bind between starting a conventional war he didn’t want and taking a loser’s badge, decided to send in ground troops, fired Glazyev, put the Ministry of Defense in charge of the war, assassinated all the charismatic warlords of the Donbas and replaced them with people who would actually follow orders, and tried to get the Ukrainians to give up European integration at the negotiating table.

But Putin still couldn’t get what he wanted from Ukraine. His demand that Ukraine economically integrate with Russia instead of Europe was tantamount to demanding Ukraine stay poor forever. Even setting aside the principle of the thing, they’d rather just keep fighting the war.^[128]

Putin, being both economically illiterate and deeply racist against Ukrainians, just couldn't grok this—neither intuitively nor through empathy. Instead, he kept blaming the US, while his conspiracy-minded advisers and propagandists continued to cheer him on. The nationalists were unhappy because they wanted him to invade all of Ukraine, while the liberals were upset because American sanctions were hurting the Russian economy. To quote Alexander Dugin in *Putin v. The People...*^[129]

“Crimea was the culmination point—the last stop before completely changing the logic of the development of modern Russia. But it didn't happen. I don't know why. For the patriotic group, it was a betrayal—a betrayal by Putin of our awakening. For the liberals, it was a betrayal by Putin of globalist rules. So Putin has betrayed both parties, and that is the worst possible outcome, because we've committed half the crime but paid the full price.”^[129-1]

Backed into a corner, surrounded by yes-men, facing a ticking clock, and slowly going insane under COVID lockdown, Putin decided to cut the [Gordian knot](#)—that is, to solve a difficult and complex problem in a quick, decisive, and often forceful way—and prove once and for all that Ukrainian democracy was just a Phrygian village myth destroyed by Gordian. And so, Putin declared:

“I decided to conduct a special military operation.”

Conclusion (Sevastopol, 2014)

In August 2014, as the war was heating up, the Russian ultra-nationalist militias decided to throw a party for themselves—a celebratory bike show in newly annexed Crimea. This bike show also featured a poetry reading, an interpretive dance, and a rock opera version of the war in Ukraine as they imagined it. They spared no expense, and I highly recommend everyone watch this video because it offers one of the best windows into the mindset of the type of people who started this war—a sort of Putin-themed Psychonauts-level experience.

Full video here: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NcSmmd5g88Y> ^[130]

Defenseless riot cops are terrorized by Ukrainian Nazis, while the giant wire-mesh hands of Uncle Sam pull their puppet strings. A drumline of blood-vomiting bikers stands at attention in front of the eye pyramid of the New World Order. Speeches by Barack Obama and Adolf Hitler are spliced together and blasted over the loudspeakers, all while the leader of a motorcycle gang—who simultaneously venerates both Joseph Stalin and Tsar Nicholas as saints—reads anti-Semitic poetry reminiscent of [The Protocols of the Elders of Zion](#), declaring this war the culmination of Stalin's dream.

To get us all on the same page:

In 1993, Yeltsin was having people like this gunned down in the streets. By the late '90s, they were tolerated but still politically marginalized. By the mid-2000s, they had been folded into the official opposition. By 2012, they wielded real political power. And now, in 2014, they

parade with the backing of the president on national state television, performing in front of hundreds of thousands—dancing in a swastika formation to Hans Zimmer’s Batman music.

[130-1]

Some people look at this progression and claim it was inevitable — that this is simply the true face of Russian resurgence. But what I see instead are a series of absurd, *stupid* contingencies; the contiegencies.

I’m not writing these articles to tell you Russia is imperialist and therefore bad. I’m writing them to show that Russians are *inept* imperialists. Their imperialism isn’t a calculated, cold-blooded strategy — it’s a tragic comedy of errors driven by stupidity.

Imperialism itself is, in a grim way, rational — it makes sense in a world of strong countries and weak countries. But this?





⚡ This is a waste.

Anyone who tells you that Alexei Navalny or someone like him is just as bad as Putin because he's a smarter, subtler nationalist is profoundly underestimating the destructive power of *stupidity*.

But it's not just Russia. Last year, after the war began, the same network of pro-Kremlin conspiracy theorists we've been discussing held a rally in Washington, right in front of the White House. Here's the video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=duKeWROlp_Y^[131].

At the rally, they claimed things like:

- “The neo-Nazis that have seamlessly shifted from administration to administration—they are fully in control and they imperil humanity.”^[131-1]
- “We have the lie that one fine morning President Vladimir Putin just woke up and said, ‘Gee, I feel like invading Ukraine today.’”^[131-2]
- “The difference between our government these days and the mafia in the 1940s? Well, the mafia back then helped defeat the Nazis.”^[131-3]
- “Then we had the assassination of our President John F. Kennedy and the lie of the Magic Bullet.”^[131-4]
- “U.S. imperial aims are clearly stated in our official military policy known as full spectrum dominance.” (Yes, straight from William Engdahl’s book.)^[131-5]
- “And did I mention that all wars are Bankers’ Wars? Let me hear you say it: all wars are Bankers’ Wars.”^[131-6]
- “Then we had 9/11, allegedly perpetrated by some guy suffering kidney failure.”^[131-7]
- “And they’re standing there looking at me like I’m [__] crazy.”^[131-8]

I wish I was joking, but you can look it up yourself with the [video linked here](#) ^[131-9], see it for yourself:



It wasn’t as flashy as the bike show in Sevastopol back in 2014^[130-2], but it hit on many of the same notes—same paranoia, same conspiratorial thinking, just a different stage.

This is wild, this is not normal...

What’s striking is how this rally in Washington mirrors that 2014 Sevastopol bike show vibe^[38-1] — the surreal blend of extremist rhetoric, wild conspiracy theories, and a deep, almost performative victimhood narrative. The difference is the stage has expanded, and

now these ideas are being shouted on a world platform in 2025 by Trump Jr. the current president of U.S.A. or other far-right populist, feeding the same destructive misinformation cycles as they did back then.

This isn't just some isolated incident — it's a warning sign. A clue that we, as a society within the Western sphere, are hurtling toward full-blown Anti-intellectualism and a Post-Truth era, where even the facts laid out in this article no longer matter, fading quietly into the background noise of loud idiots spewing unfounded lies and propaganda.^[132]

But the preposterousness and denial of reality doesn't end there. The same people went on to say:

“We've been smeared as, quote, 'not anti-war.' Well, let's not confuse being anti-war with pacifism. Any leader and any people would defend themselves, as Russia is doing today. War is hell, but blaming both sides obfuscates reality.”^[131-10]

Just as the Sevastopol bike show celebrated the fusion of Russia's communist and Tsarist past, the “Rage Against the War Machine” rally was a bizarre celebration of the fusion of far right and far left. And they said it themselves, right there in front of the White House:

“Look at all of you—you're beautiful, you're beautiful. We got leftists, we got communists, right-wingers, conservatives, paleo-conservatives, libertarians, Green Party people.”^[131-11]

Furthermore, they claimed:

“If the Black Panthers can march hand in hand with the KKK down Las Vegas Boulevard to get welfare payments reinstated, we can join hands with the right wing, the libertarians, the left, the socialists, the communists—everybody—to stop a nuclear war.”^[131-12]

And even gender politics found thier way in here:

“Now, we can debate whether or not teenage girls should have to share locker rooms or compete in athletics against biological males another time. But I just want to say, in my experience, it's not so much a matter of right or left—it's really a question of the few elites at the top versus all the rest of us.”^[131-13]

See, now it's neither right nor left—it's all about fighting a secret cabal of bankers who are supposedly responsible for all wars throughout the history. These very people depicted below:



are a joke, but their absurd ideas have drowned out any meaningful discussion in alternative media. So today, the world is polarized between this:

“We have to understand that the COVID-19 response—lockdowns and experimental injections—were deadly war measures imposed against us the people of U.S.A. by the Pentagon.”^[131-14]

...and the States Departments, researchers, scientists, and just people who actually care.

The result is a kind of reverse [McCarthyism](#): if you dissent from their narrow vision of how the world works, you're accused of secretly being loyal to the United States. A narrative has taken hold that these people—whether you call them free thinkers, tankies, trolls, the horseshoe left, the horseshoe right, or populists—are nothing more than tools of Russian foreign policy and propaganda. But espionage and attempts to destabilize nations from within are hardly new inventions, one might think. So the idea that the Russian government might be feeding talking points to useful idiots abroad shouldn't shock anyone—it's just Cold War tactics in a new wrapper.

But as we've unequivocally seen, the flow of disinformation has mostly gone the other way. Putin has been fooled just as much as he's fooled others. What this war has made clear—at least to me—is that there is no master plan. There isn't any greater narrative to be told here. Forget all the myths, that the media has spun about the Kremlin. The truth all along was that these guys...



...these guys are not bright, and things just got out of hand.

And that's it. That's the cause of the war in Ukraine. It really is just Russia defending itself — or more precisely, defending against shadows and ghosts. That's why Putin has been, and will remain, both impossible to appease and impossible to deter. And that's why there won't be a deal. The Russian ruling class just has to be allowed to self-immolate until living in the real world finally becomes preferable again.

But understanding the war doesn't mean understanding Putin or real geopolitics. It means understanding the mass hysteria that has sprung up around these incredibly dumb conspiracy theories and the grifters who profit from them. So why has this stupid conspiracy theory taken the world by storm?

The bad answer has been to blame the internet.

The New Radicalization of the Internet

Jihadists and right-wing extremists use remarkably similar social media strategies.

Nov. 24, 2018



Woody Harrington

And while the internet does drive people crazy, it does so by reinforcing what people already want to believe. It doesn't explain *why* people wanted to believe those things in the first place.

I think the timing here is key. It's no coincidence that a conspiracy theory claiming all revolutions are fake took off in the 2010s — a decade defined by failed revolutions (in Tunis, Moscow, Manama, Hong Kong, New York, Cairo, Athens, Damascus, Istanbul, Minsk).

Failed revolutions generate two types of people: paranoid reactionaries, eager to make bottom-up political change impossible; and disappointed revolutionaries, eager to believe bottom-up change is impossible as an excuse for their own failures because of some Deep State. And the Arab Spring added a third group: guilty bystanders. People think the Iraq War discredited democracy promotion, but it only discredited promoting democracy through aggressive war. The West was still happy to see spontaneous moves toward democracy, like in 2011. But sometime between the Benghazi consulate attack and the fall of Mosul, the West lost its nerve and, much like Putin, decided dictatorship's stability might be preferable to revolutionary chaos. This meant standing by and letting what happened in Syria... happen.



As the Syrian situation became more horrific, more people craved a story that excused their responsibility. Around the same time, when Russia intervened in Aleppo and Idlib, Russian English-language propaganda started pushing Putin's pet conspiracy theory: the Arab Spring was really just another CIA Color Revolution.

This theory was perfect for a West looking to wash its hands of Syria. If the Arab Spring had been real, not intervening in Syria for "stability" would be morally fraught — sacrificing hundreds of thousands of lives for convenience. But if the Arab Spring was all a CIA plot, then opposing intervention in Syria becomes a selfless, brave, even heroic stand against powerful forces. You get to pat yourself on the back for humanitarianism — all while watching a city get blown to bits.

What all these Color Revolution stories share is an attempt to nullify democracy — not necessarily to destroy it outright, although that is probably the broader objective at large, but to prove it cannot actually exist. Putin and other dictators want to prove democracy is a sham so people won't overthrow them. A critical mass of Westerners have embraced this narrative for a much sadder reason: if it's true, no one has to take responsibility for anything.

If democracy can't exist, the Russian people don't have to ask what opportunities they threw away through cowardice or cynicism. If everything is controlled by Deep State puppet strings, no one in America has moral responsibility for the Iraq War. If democracy never really existed, it was never truly at stake in Syria — and so on.

The global flight to conspiracy theories is usually framed as helpless idiots who don't know who to trust, having been lied to by "respectable" authorities, and who fall prey to insane grifters. But I don't think people are that stupid. If anything, they're smart enough to only embrace conspiracy theories that exonerate them of wrongdoing.

What we really have here is a kind of crowdsourced alibi. People are trading their freedom for innocence. Populist leaders gladly tell people they're innocent in exchange for power. The only hole in the alibi is Ukraine. Of all the revolutions in the 2010s, only one succeeded: Euromaidan. Ukrainians took their destiny into their own hands and won. That's why they have to die — because if they can do it, so can we. We could have done it.

Which means democracy is real and possible. And the rest of us do bear responsibility for what's going wrong in our politics.

That's why supporters and opponents alike feel in their guts that this war is a test of democracy—not just because Ukraine happened to be a democracy and Russia happened to be a dictatorship, but because Russia and the world have turned this war into a test of whether ordinary people can still rise up against entrenched power and win. And a surprising number of people want that to be impossible.

So yeah, that's pretty bleak — but don't worry, I think I can make it bleaker.

Post Scriptum

Russia isn't the only country where the LaRouche movement and similar conspiracy-driven factions have wormed their way into influential circles. For instance, 15 U.S. Representatives from the Schiller Institute (yes, that exact group LaRouche created) recently visited China to "learn about the country's development." On their visit, they met with students and faculty from Singa University in Beijing to "exchange views on mutual concerns."^{[133][134][135]}

Since around 2015, Chinese media has been flooded with stories warning of an imminent American-backed Color Revolution in China. This rhetoric peaked during the Hong Kong protests but also appears regularly in coverage about Xinjiang, where the "strike hard" campaign is promoted as a necessary preemptive measure against separatism allegedly funded by the National Endowment for Democracy. According to at least one White House staffer, in private conversations with President Xi Jinping, the Chinese leader has explicitly voiced concerns about the threat of a Color Revolution.^[134-1]

Maybe this is just propaganda, and maybe no one in the Central Committee truly believes this paranoid conspiracy theory. Maybe behind the wild accusations there's a more sober, strategic calculus. But that's the same bet we made with Russia.

What I *do* know is that, regardless of what the Chinese leadership actually believes, Chinese media is now saturated with American anti-war conspiracy theorists explaining to the Chinese people that America hates them and is planning a preemptive war.

As *The Base Nation* put it:

"China itself is under threat. These American bases form a giant noose encircling China with missiles, bombers, warships."

and continued:

"The United States is threatening war with China. In one sense, is the US already at war with China? Yes — on the ground and in the air."

This dovetails perfectly with right-wing anti-war conspiracy theorists in the U.S. — people like [Robert F. Kennedy Jr.](#) — who are now telling the American public that *they* are already under attack from the Chinese government.

As Carl Tuckers from Fox News recently claimed:

"There's a hidden China menace right here on our soil. Sister cities... We spend an awful lot of time talking about China — its intentions, its crimes, its treatment of dogs."

And that:

"They're going to attack with a bolt from the blue. They're going to destroy our satellites in orbit, our communications equipment. We won't be fighting about transgender issues on TikTok anymore — because TikTok won't even work in the United States."

If you look at the modern anti-war movement's list of "accomplishments," starting the war in Ukraine might end up being just a footnote.

And what is there to say about Gaza... Sudan... Yemen... what about the future wars... what if China decides to invade Taiwan, or North Korea attacks the South... What then? Should we just let it happen? Or will we just attach the label that it must have happened... that it was inevitable...? And these are not the result of some looming cataclysms on our Earth—be it climate change or natural disasters. All of this is due to some people at the top failing to come to an understanding with a few other high-ranking officials. It's human folly. The only question each of us should ask ourselves is: just how many more red lines will we allow to be crossed by the king-makers, fools and grifters before we've had enough?

I don't have any real answer to those questions. Neither can I predict what might be the best solution to this dilemma. All I want the reader to do is—next time he or she finds themselves wondering why something happened—to instead ask: Was that really all inevitable, or could something be done to prevent this? And if one might think that it's the responsibility of those at the top to prevent this, to avoid the suffering of the innocent or find a compromise in the cut-throat politics... he or she should keep in mind, that: if you don't expect yourself to do anything of sort, why should anyone else be expected to carry that burden for you?

On Ukraine by Kacper Patryk Sobczak

Reference Material

1. For more about the 90s in Ukraine see Åslund, Anders. How Ukraine Became a Market Economy and Democracy. Illustrated, Peterson Institute for International Economics, 2009.(B) and Taras Kuzio (2007) Oligarchs, Tapes and Oranges: 'Kuchmagate' to the Orange Revolution, Journal of Communist Studies and Transition Politics, <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/pdf/1...> I should note there is one major difference between Ukraine and the typical post-Soviet story: Whereas most Eastern European countries embarked on a program of "Shock Therapy," Ukraine's transition from socialism to capitalism was extremely gradual.(C) It was, in fact, quite fashionable among neoliberal economists to point to Ukraine's relatively anemic growth as proof that they were right about Shock Therapy, and the negative effects of Shock Therapy on Russia and Poland represented the best of a set of bad options. You don't hear that argument so often now. ↩ ↩
2. (Audio of the released section of the tapes  [• Аудіозаписи Мельниченка](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=...) Transcript of gongadze threats <https://www.rferl.org/a/1057789.html> Story about sales to Iraq <https://publicintegrity.org/national-...>) ↩
3. Åslund, A 2009 p. 129-139 ↩
4. Åslund, A 2009, p. 145 ↩
5. It's worth quoting Åslund here, because the story is funny: "Kuchma courted NATO by all means. In May 2002, he announced that Ukraine's ultimate goal was to join NATO. In November 2002, NATO

held a summit in Prague, which Kuchma gate-crashed despite NATO having made clear that it did not invite him. ↩

6. Åslund, A 2009, p. 180-185 ↩
7. The Testimony of Viktor Yushchenko for the George W. Bush Presidential Library's "Freedom Collection" contains numerous examples of fraud schemes. 
• [Viktor Yushchenko: The Second Round of the...](#) ↩
8. More "Freedom Collection" testimony detailing the negotiations between Yushchenko, the security services and Kuchma. (D)  • [Viktor Yushchenko_The Orange Revolution](#) ↩
9. Åslund, A 2009 p. 106-112 ↩
10. Taras Kuzio (2012) Yushchenko versus Tymoshenko: Why Ukraine's National Democrats Are Divide p. 201-228 <https://demokratizatsiya.pub/archives...> ↩
11. <https://www.pravda.com.ua/articles/20...> <https://www.pravda.com.ua/articles/20...> ↩
12. Piece about the West's backlash to Tymoshenko's imprisonment 
• [German doctors plead for Tymoshenko treatment](#) ↩
13. <https://www.buzzfeednews.com/article/...> ↩ ↩
14. A Full transcript of the memo Glazyev wrote to the Kremlin can be found linked here. While Glazyev denies writing the memo, he did admit it came from the Kremlin and it bears several own eccentric ideological ideas fixes. <https://zn.ua/ukr/internal/o-kompleks...> ↩
15. Article detailing the sanctions Russia put in place beginning in the summer of 2013. <https://www.economist.com/europe/2013...> ↩ ↩
16. [Yanukovich says Ukraine-EU deal is suspended, not cancelled](#) ↩
17. <https://www.osw.waw.pl/en/publikacje/...> ↩
18. Summary of the provisions of the protest law. <https://www.bbc.com/ukrainian/politic...> ↩
19. The pattern of the east only getting involved after the anti-protest laws can be seen here: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Euromai...> ↩
20. A memo leaked during the Donbas war from an agent in Kyiv to the Kremlin, shows the thinking.(E) <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/02/26/wo...> ↩
21. The passive voice here is intentional, of course. There's still no hard evidence of who started shooting and who's responsible for all of the shootings that day. There's a consensus on a few main points. There was a sniper in the music conservatory, a member of Maidan self-defense, who shot at Berkut to with a hunting rifle, pushing them back from the closest barricade. (F) He claims he was only aiming to maim, but there were several fatalities among the police.) In response, the Berkut retreated from one barricade back to another barracade further from the maidan. While retreating, the Berkut fired indiscriminately not at the sniper but at the crowd of mostly unarmed protesters in the street below. This shooting caused the majority of the fatalities. (G) The report from political scientist Ivan Katchenovski, that bounces around the internet occasionally, that supposedly proves the vast majority of the fatalities came from snipers from Pravy Sektor, in fact, proves no such thing. much of the evidence that individual protesters "couldn't" have been shot by police is based on details in videos too grainy to actually make out, Katchenovski's notes and interpretations of coroner's reports that are not publicly available, and unjustified leaps in logic based on bullet wound trajectory. Even more egregiously, Katchenovski presents zero evidence about the Hotel Ukraine sniper. Things that will be addressed in later entries so please don't be angry with me for not including here) There was, in addition to this exchange, other sniper attacks, whose identity(s) have yet to be revealed, who attacked both police and protesters throughout the day. ↩
22. Key to note here, is that the Times' source here is Alexander Khodakovsky, who as a leader of the Donetsk's People's Republic has no reason to lie to protect the protesters.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2015/01/04/world/europe/ukraine-leader-was-defeated-even-before-he-was-ousted.html>) ↩

23. Dobkin, the governor of Kharkiv oblast, who met with Yanukovych after he fled Kyiv but before he fled the country says that Yanukovych mentioned nothing about an assassination plot and was still trying to find a political solution out of the bind. <https://www.nytimes.com/2014/02/24/world/europe/as-his-fortunes-fell-in-ukraine-a-president-clung-to-illusions.html> ↩
24. Viktor Medvedchuk, mainly, but Russian state and oligarch owned media also broadcasts inside eastern Ukraine. ↩
25. There were also Russians bussed in directly from across the border. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=urg1NTAo53k> ↩
26. Link to the English transcript of cellphone call <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0w78QuxBUe0> Better context for the provenience of the leak. It should be noted that Konstantine Zatulin, the man Glazyev is talking to, has confessed the recording is real. <https://foreignpolicyblogs.com/2018/09/13/the-glazyev-tapes-origins-of-the-donbas-conflict-and-minsk-agreements/> ↩
27. Spetznaz units first started mobilizing in February 23rd. https://www.rand.org/content/dam/rand/pubs/research_reports/RR1400/RR1498/RAND_RR1498.pdf p. 7) ↩
28. There was, in addition to the Maxar satellite photos. Multiple dashcam and phone videos from Russians posted to VKontakte and Tik Tok showing tanks and helicopters moving towards the border. <https://www.bellingcat.com/resources/how-tos/2022/02/08/tracking-russian-military-vehicles-on-the-move/> Rob Lee's twitter feed is probably still the best archive, and is itself archived in the way back machine. <https://twitter.com/RALee85>) ↩
29. Wikipedia has the handiest list of who was kidnapped and whether they were released or killed. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Siege_of_Sloviansk#Hostages_and_abductions The reporter from Vice who was kidnapped also produced an episode about his experience. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tQGRJN4Radk> ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩
30. Russian opposition leader Boris Nemtsov, before his death, commissioned a report on the origins of the Donbas war, It's survey of Russian media showed that Right Sektor, the small far-right militia formed during the Maidan protests received more press coverage than any other political organization in the world, including Putin's own United Russia. <https://web.archive.org/web/20150529130114/http://4freerussia.org/putin.war/Putin.War-Eng.pdf> There are also phone recordings of Sergei Glazyev, Russia's minister for Eurasian integration, organizing mobs for hire to cause instability in Eastern Ukraine. ↩
31. Svoboda, being a part of the opposition coalition also got ministerial posts, but they were safely kept away from the important power ministries. Those posts were: Vice Prime Minister for humanitarian policy. Minister of Agrarian Policy and Food. Minister of Ecology and Natural Resources. No word on whether or not this led to the implementation of any sort of anti-semitic fishing quota.) ↩ ↩
32. Russia is not particularly invested in keeping this part of the story secret and so not only have many of the Russian agents who organized the siege of Slavyansk done interviews, several have commercially published their memoirs. Girkin himself has done two long form TV interviews, where he describes in detail his time in Ukraine. His war crime live blogging was also published under the name Slavyansk Diaries. I am relying primarily on the English translation of the memoirs of another fighter named Alexander Zhuchkovsky named 85 Days in Slavyansk. https://www.amazon.com/dp/B09YXN565T/ref=dp-kindle-redirect?_encoding=UTF8&btkr=1 But also on Igor Girkin's' interview with Dmitry Gordon https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hf6K6pjK_Yw) ↩ ↩ ↩

33. There is some disagreement both among Ukrainian observers and the Russian veterans as to whether this pogrom was really about race, or an attempt Ponomaryov monopolize the local drug trade for himself. Zhuchkovsky leans towards the latter explanation.
<https://www.nytimes.com/video/world/europe/100000002837554/ukrainian-roma-face-threats-and-violence.html> ↩
34. Ukrainian security services which had hacked Girkin's phone during the siege, released two phone calls regarding the fate of Rybak. One call in which Girkin tells the commander of the Russian battalion in Horlivka, Igor Bezler, to "take care" of Rybak. And a second call from Girkin to Ponomaryov, asking him to do something about the body in the police in the station because it's starting to stink. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=k3s9qgDh5pw> ↩ ↩
35. There was a lengthy investigation into the fire conducted by an NGO expert panel. They have published a timeline of the events of the day recreated through compiling cellphone and tv camera footage of the fight. Their chronology is here: <https://2maygroup.blogspot.com/2015/12/the-chronology-of-events-that-occurred.html> And a YouTube playlist of all the corresponding videos with time stamps is here: https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL1VsJWkUn2D4c8_U3FffAUJV_XPjPpt4Z (Warning: These videos can be quite graphic) ↩
36. The People's Governor of the DNR Pavel Gubarev was a member of this organization ↩
37. https://english.elpais.com/elpais/2015/02/27/inenglish/1425051026_915897.html ↩
38. The night wolves also participated in the invasion of Crimea. And held a celebratory biker rally in the aftermath of the annexation that is the single most insane thing I have ever seen. Involving synchronized Swastika dancing to the Dark Knight soundtrack, a blood-vomiting drumline, the head of a biker gang reading antisemitic poetry, a 20-foot-tall illuminati pyramid, capped off by a ska song about how Ukraine is not a real country. <https://youtu.be/NPnb97ybtIU?t=157>) ↩ ↩
39. Zhuchkovsky is very cagey about how much Russia was supplying in the early months of the war, for instance he makes a lot of noise about having captured four anti-tank missiles from Ukraine and implies they were the only anti-tank missiles they had. But he reports far more than four tanks and aircraft being shot down. (85 Days always refers to aircraft shootdowns in the passive voice). The Ukrainians for their part, point out that their MANPADS are programmed to not fire on their own aircraft, and the militia certainly wouldn't have had the tools to override the software. There are also lots of conflicting reports about to what extent aid sent by Russia made it to Ukraine but not to Sloviansk, either because other rebel commanders closer to the border appropriated them or sold them off for quick cash ↩ ↩
40. 85 Days in Slavyansk, Zhuchkovsky. The New York Times also conducted an informal survey of Sloviansk residents while it was being encircled by Russian forces this year. They estimated that about half of the residents who had refused to evacuate, who constitute about a quarter of the population were looking forward to rejoining Russia. Putting the number of genuine pro-Russians at somewhere near 12 to 13%. <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/07/08/world/europe/ukraine-sloviansk-russia.html> ↩ ↩
41. This did not prevent Russia from trying to fabricate atrocities, Russian news spun a wild tale about Ukrainian soldiers tying a mother to the back of a tank and dragging her to death over the pavement, while they literally nailed her son to a wooden cross. This story made decent headway among Russian nationalist circles but was never picked up the English language pro Russian press since it was believed few people, even if sympathetic to Russia, would be stupid enough to believe it. Unrelatedly Haz from Infrared believes it. ↩
42. <https://web.archive.org/web/20150110150440/http://foreignpolicy.com/2014/07/12/all-is-not-well-in-novorossiya/> ↩
43. The video of this fight can be found here. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UOvWNTOKX2c> And a transcript of the argument can be found here. <https://eot.su/node/17392> ↩

44. https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/08/HPS_English.pdf While this is a US deep state source, like the satellite photos of 2022, it is a compilation of open-source intelligence, and can (and was) independently verified. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2zsslFN2mso> ↩
45. Divvying up civilian casualties for a given time period, let alone assigning blame for those casualties is dicey. But as the only heavy combat was happening in Sloviansk at this part of the war, we can use estimates of civilian casualties for the siege of Sloviansk. There were 20 civilian casualties in the early low intensity part of the siege, mostly killed by the Russians. There's no official count for civilian casualties during the heavier fighting of the siege, but 85 Days gives an estimate that about 5 civilians died a day as a result of Ukrainian shelling. This is almost certainly a lie, or at least a gross exaggeration, since there were journalists in the city (including journalists sympathetic to the DNR like Graham Philips), none of whom mention anything like that amount of bloodshed. However, even if it were true, it would put the civilian casualties attributable to Ukraine, in the range of 150-200 people. MH17 killed 298 people. ↩
46. https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/08/HPS_English.pdf
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2zsslFN2mso> Nemtsov Report p 19 - 41
<https://web.archive.org/web/20150529130114/http://4freerussia.org/putin.war/Putin.War-Eng.pdf>
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C66mAkS1ZfM> ↩ ↩
47. For a good read on Russia's increasing radicalization in this time period see The Road to Unfreedom by Timothy Snyder, Chapter 5. ↩
48. The text of the Minsk protocol can be seen here. <https://informnapalm.org/4457-tochnaya-karta-razgranicheniya-sil-na-donbasse/> ↩
49. https://static.rusi.org/201503_bp_russian_forces_in_ukraine_0.pdf ↩
50. This was probably the bloodiest battle of the war in terms of civilian casualties ↩
51. This is the bloodiest single artillery attack on a city in the war. The claims about constant Ukrainian are in a sense, an attempt at projection. And it was not uncommon to see Russian propaganda accounts use footage of the Mariupol strike and pass it off as Ukrainian attacks on Donetsk. ↩
52. Explained further in later part of this article ↩ ↩
53. More about this in later part of article ↩ ↩
54. <https://www.dw.com/en/germans-say-russia-is-more-reliable-than-the-united-states/a-41728582>) ↩ ↩
55. <https://www.nytimes.com/2014/04/20/world/europe/in-cold-war-echo-obama-strategy-writes-off-putin.html?searchResultPosition=9> ↩
56. <https://www.rferl.org/a/czech-republic-russia-depot-blast-gallery-expulsions/31209726.html> ↩
57. It is worth noting that the natural gas theory is entirely implausible. By annexing Crimea, Russia only stole about 60-70 trillion cubic feet of natural gas. Which could only be tapped (expensively) at a rate of about 1 trillion cf a year, max. This is enough to damage Ukraine's economy but not enough to change the picture as far as energy strategy in Europe. Norway alone exports 4 trillion cf of natural gas a year. ↩
58. <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president...> ↩ ↩
59. Iraq, of course, is the canonical example of America being unable to get the rest of NATO to join in on a military adventure. People with a more conspiratorial view of NATO sometimes point to the use of NATO infrastructure for the interventions in Kosovo and Libya, but in both these cases this was the result of a compromise in a situation in which Europe wanted the war more than the US, but didn't have the means to fight it on it's own. (The Libyan war was an initiative of Nicholas Sarkozy, and Clinton had promised not to send ground troops to Yugoslavia due to the wars unpopularity, and so making it a "NATO" mission allowed) ↩
60.  [• Why is Ukraine the West's Fault? Featuring...](#) 
[• Vladimir Pozner: How the United States Cre...](#)  [• Stephen F. Cohen: The Ukrainian Crisis -](#)

61. The evidence that America pressured Russia into doing Shock Therapy is surprisingly thin, given it's a common assumption. I read the 4 most popular English language accounts of Russia in the 90s that make this claim and all of them basically either rely on fraudulent sources or none at all. The 1998 Nation magazine article "The Harvard Boys Do Russia" by Janine Wedel which is often presented as evidence, is mostly based on a fictional book called "How America Created the New Oligarchy" by a woman named Anne Williamson, who seems to have tried to make a career of shopping around a manuscript to different writers telling them that it was for a book that was just about to be published, but never was. "The Shock Doctrine" by Naomi Klein alleges that Bush pressured Gorbachev to do shock therapy by threatening to withhold aid unless Gorbachev gave up on gradual reform at the 1991 G7 meeting, however this contradicts both the declassified transcript of the conversation, and the description of the event in Gorbachev's memoirs. "Globalization and It's Discontents" by Joseph Stiglitz mostly covers Stiglitz tenure at the World Bank and the CEA, which mostly took place after Yeltsin had given up on Shock Therapy in 1994, but he blames Larry Summers for not making more aid dependent on legal reform rather than making it dependent on more privatization. As I'll describe later, the decision to give Russia lots of aid in 1996 was a political decision and didn't hinge on either privatization or rule of law. ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩
62. In the English transcript, it's explicitly stated that this was a hypothetical deal that could be made at the coming German reunification negotiations. When those negotiations actually came and the white house had revoked the offer, Gorbachev didn't have the leverage to prevent German reunification, and so had to settle for an agreement that no NATO infrastructure would be deployed on East German soil (and aid money). ↩
63. To make a long story short, James Bakker's offer was a hypothetical of what could be agreed to at a six party negotiation on the terms by which East and West Germany would be reunified. During that conference, America was able to negotiate the Soviets down to a ban on deployments of non-German NATO troops to East Germany. But, the Germans, desperate to get the deal done, decided to grease the skids by telling the Russians there would be no expansion, behind the American delegation's back. Sarotte, M. E. "Not One Inch: America, Russia, and The Making of the Post-Cold War Stalemate" Ch. 3 ↩
64. Gorbachev M. S. "Memoirs" 1996 Ch. 27-29 ↩
65. Interview with Grigori Yavlinsky for PBS Frontline, 2000
http://www.pbs.org/wgbh/commandingheights/shared/miniextlo/int_grigoriyavlinsky.html#5 State Department Transcript of G7 meeting with Gorbachev, 1991
<https://nsarchive.gwu.edu/document/28348-document-28-g-7-meeting-president-gorbachev-london-july-17-1991>) ↩ ↩ ↩
66. PBS Interview with Yegor Gaidar and Anatoly Chubais for Frontline, 2000.
http://www.pbs.org/wgbh/commandingheights/shared/miniextlo/int_anatoliichubais.html
http://www.pbs.org/wgbh/commandingheights/shared/miniextlo/int_yegorgaidar.html ↩
67. Namely George Soros and the CIA. And they would, of course, find plenty of allies in this conspiracy mongering from the Western left, which was not really interested in Russia, but was interested in using the Russian catastrophe to discredit the dogmatic, hyper-libertarian economic ideology that was ravaging their countries. ↩
68. Sarotte, M. E. "Not One Inch: America, Russia, and The Making of the Post-Cold War Stalemate" Ch. 4 Transcript of Clinton meeting with leaders of Eastern Europe
<https://nsarchive.gwu.edu/document/16384-document-12-president-s-luncheon-plenary> ↩
69. Poland's Nuclear Threat: Sarotte, M. E. "Not One Inch: America, Russia, and The Making of the Post-Cold War Stalemate" Ch. 4 Poland's Drunken Letter Gambit Sarotte, M. E. "Not One Inch: America, Russia, and The Making of the Post-Cold War Stalemate" Ch. 5 ↩ ↩

70. Sarotte, M. E. "Not One Inch: America, Russia, and The Making of the Post-Cold War Stalemate" Ch. 6... Archive of correspondences between Whitehouse and Kremlin: <https://nsarchive.gwu.edu/briefing-book/russia-programs/2018-03-16/nato-expansion-what-yeltsin-heard> ↩ ↩
71. Sarotte, M. E. "Not One Inch: America, Russia, and The Making of the Post-Cold War Stalemate" Ch. 8 Transcript of Yeltsin-Clinton conversation in which Clinton promises not to make any announcements until after Yeltsin's reelection <https://nsarchive.gwu.edu/document/16391-document-19-summary-report-one-one-meeting> ↩ ↩
72. For an interesting example of the paranoia in the US. See this call-in segment on C-SPAN with future ambassador to Russia Michael McFaul. IN which 3 callers accuse Clinton of being in league with Russia to betray the country. <https://www.c-span.org/video/?157485-1/us-russia-summit> ↩
73. Why did George Bush do this? Why scare the Russians for no reason, if there wasn't really any plan yet to let Ukraine in NATO? I have a theory that I cannot prove, but feel pretty confident in. I think it was a political favor to Viktor Yushchenko, who Bush had gotten close to over the previous 4 years. If you go back to part 1 of this series, you'll remember that 2008 is when Yushchenko's presidency was starting to go off the rails, and even then, it was looking like he wouldn't get reelected. What I suspect was happening was that Bush was trying to give Yushchenko something, anything, that Yushchenko could present to his voters as some kind of progress in stabilizing the country. But that didn't come to fruition, and so... ↩
74. For a good example of the sort of unhinged anger Clinton provoked in the neoconservative movement, see the following Weekly Standard articles: 1. <https://archive.org/details/the-weekly-standard-1999-04-19/page/n17/mode/2up> 2. <https://archive.org/details/the-weekly-standard-1996-09-30/page/n11/mode/2up> 3. <https://archive.org/details/the-weekly-standard-1998-02-02/page/n17/mode/2up>

To neoconservatives, this represented a denial of the reality that America was metaphysically, ontologically good rather than like any other country. So when they took power, they set out intentionally to undermine international organizations, international law, and consensus building as a principle, since in their minds these were all immoral constraints on America's unilateral power.^[75] Their first move to this end was to tear up the anti-ballistic missile treaty. ↩ ↩

75. These two articles were both written by Charles Krauthammer, one just before 9/11 and one just after, what's striking is how similar both are despite this. In one particularly telling passage Krauthammer says America should encourage Russia to reassert it's sphere of influence, instead of insisting Russia's neighbors should have their sovereignty respected. a. [The Weekly Standard, Volume 6, Number 36, June 4, 2001 : The Weekly Standard : Free Download, Borrow, and Streaming : Internet Archive](#) b. [The Weekly Standard, Volume 7, Number 9, November 12, 2001 : The Weekly Standard : Free Download, Borrow, and Streaming : Internet Archive](#) ↩
76. The text can be found here: [American Service-Members' Protection Act \(state.gov\)](#) ↩
77. [Chapter 3. Perceived Threats and Allies Pew Research Center](#) ↩
78. [Seventy-Two Percent of Americans Support War Against Iraq on gallup.com](#) ↩
79. This way of talking about the Iraq War is so ubiquitous, it's hard to point to a prototypical example, but I think the closest thing to a first draft of this popular history can be found in Bill Moyers PBS documentary "Buying the War":[Bill Moyers Journal: Buying the War on Vimeo](#) ↩
80. There will probably be some objections to my characterization of The Israel Lobby, but make no mistake. The primary thesis of "The Israel Lobby" is that the Israel Lobby was the driving force behind the decision to invade Iraq. In the original white paper ([Link](#)), about a quarter of the text is devoted to proving the Israel Lobby is responsible for the Iraq War, whereas, for example, little of it is devoted to exploring how the lobby affected America's handling of the peace process (Oslo gets one sentence). Furthermore, while the book does have an obligatory disclaimer that not all Jews are in the Israel Lobby and the Israel Lobby isn't all Jews. The book doesn't offer any examples of dispensationalist

Christian Zionists affecting foreign policy, and it isn't particularly shy about labelling any Jewish organization and even individual Jewish journalists as being part of the "Lobby," a tic you can also spot in Walt's later writing on the topic. [I don't mean to say I told you so, but... – Foreign Policy](#) ↩ ↩

81. Passages about Bush's thinking come from Robert Draper's *To Start a War*. Draper, Robert. *To Start a War: How the Bush Administration Took America Into Iraq*. United States: Penguin Publishing Group, 2021. It's worth comparing the timeline of the decision to invade Iraq, the propaganda drive to build support for the war, and the week by week polling of support for the war. [Seventy-Two Percent of Americans Support War Against Iraq \(gallup.com\)](#) Support for an invasion of Iraq peaked in October 2001, than slowly mellowed down to about 60% support in the spring of 2002, where it stayed completely flat except for a 5 point bump following Colin Powell's presentation at the UN, which was wiped out by Hussein's decision to start cooperating with inspectors the week after. Bush himself didn't decide to invade Iraq until the summer of 2002 (Draper), and the media campaign to drum up support for the war didn't begin until August. Wolfowitz individually began trying to drum up support as early as September 2001, but his influence didn't expend very far past the *Weekly Standard* and the *National Review*. If anything, media coverage of the impending war dampened support, simply by the fact that by talking about the possible links between Saddam and Al-Qaeda, the MSM helped educate Americans on the fact that the Iraqi government and Al-Qaeda were two different organizations with dramatically different goals. ↩
82. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5hXAkCK5qRk> I'll also provide a sampling of Executive Intelligence Review articles so you can get the vibe: [Africa Ravaged by Qaddafi and IMF \(larouchepub.com\)](#) , [George Soros: the Queen's drug pusher \(larouchepub.com\)](#) , [The Anglo-Soviet Circles that Created Kissinger \(larouchepub.com\)](#) ↩
83. <https://www.nytimes.com/1974/01/20/archives/how-a-radicalleft-group-moved-toward-savagery-progression-to.html> ↩
84. LaRouche's influence in American intelligence was somewhat limited, he appears to have been useful to the CIA as a source about what the South African Intelligence agencies were up to in Angola, since LaRouche was working for South African intelligence spying on and attacking anti-apartheid groups in America. (THE LAROCHE CONNECTION cia.gov)(<https://www.cia.gov/readingroom/docs/CIA-RDP90-00806R000100640021-7.pdf>) [The President's News Conference - 8/12/86](#) His influence in 1990s Russia is also attested to by a story found in Donald Rumsfeld memoirs, where Rumsfeld complains that he had to spend 20 minutes convincing the Russian general staff that LaRouche had not been the mastermind of Reagan's SDI program. Rumsfeld, Donald. *Known and Unknown: A Memoir*. N.p.: Penguin Publishing Group, 2011. Ch. 23 ↩
85. [Bill Gates talks about 'vaccines to reduce population', by F. William Engdahl \(voltage.net.org\)](#) ↩
86. [The Secret Financial Network behind 'Wizard' George Soros \(larouchepub.com\)](#); [Soros robs the poor, gives to the rich \(larouchepub.com\)](#); [The Spreading Web of George Soros \(larouchepub.com\)](#) ↩
87. In addition to the books on screen: CAQ56-1996-2 (covertactionmagazine.com)] (<https://covertactionmagazine.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/01/CAQ56-1996-2.pdf>) [CAQ65-1998-2 \(covertactionmagazine.com\)](#) and while I don't agree with all the contents of the video, This Kraut video contains a useful list of weird things Noam Chomsky has said about Yugoslavia: [Why Noam Chomsky is garbage](#) ↩
88. <https://covertactionmagazine.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/01/CAQ74-2002-3.pdf> This article from "World Socialist Web Site" is the earliest example of the fully fleshed out account of Color Revolution Theory I could find. ↩
89. [Pillars of Russia's Disinformation and Propaganda Ecosystem \(state.gov\)](#) ↩
90. [As Putin Sees It, Shevardnadze Had It Coming - WSJ](#) Zygar, Mikhail. *All the Kremlin's Men: Inside the Court of Vladimir Putin*. United States: PublicAffairs, 2016. p.105 ↩

91. Georgia's "rose revolution": a made-in-America coup - World Socialist Web Site (wsws.org)] (<https://www.wsws.org/en/articles/2003/12/geor-d05.html>) ↩
92. [The Weekly Standard, Volume 9, Number 35, May 24, 2004 : The Weekly Standard : Free Download, Borrow, and Streaming : Internet Archive](#) ↩
93. Zygar, Mikhail. All the Kremlin's Men: Inside the Court of Vladimir Putin. United States: PublicAffairs, 2016. P.90 - 107 ↩
94. Ibid ↩ ↩
95. Popovic, Srdja., Miller, Matthew. Blueprint for Revolution: How to Use Rice Pudding, Lego Men, and Other Nonviolent Techniques to Galvanize Communities, Overthrow Dictators, Or Simply Change the World. United States: Random House Publishing Group, 2015. [Bringing Down a Dictator - English \(high definition\) - YouTube](#) ↩ ↩
96. [Who Really Brought Down Milosevic? - The New York Times \(nytimes.com\)](#) Mitchell, Lincoln A.. The Color Revolutions. United Kingdom: University of Pennsylvania Press, Incorporated, 2012. ↩ ↩
97. Herd, Graeme P. "Russia and the 'Orange Revolution': Response, Rhetoric, Reality?" Connections 4, no. 2 (2005): 15–28. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/26323167>.] ↩
98. [Purple Revolution | National Review](#) , [Bush Portrays Iraq Vote as Step in a Global March to Freedom - The New York Times \(nytimes.com\)](#) , [President Addresses and Thanks Citizens of Slovakia \(archives.gov\)](#) ↩
99. [U.S.-Russia Relations | February 24, 2005 00:00:00 | C-SPAN.org](#) ↩
100. Engdahl, F. William. Full Spectrum Dominance: Totalitarian Democracy in the New World Order. United States: Progressive Press, 2011. ↩
101. Ibid, [Color Revolutions, Geopolitics and the Baku Pipeline - Global ResearchGlobal Research - Centre for Research on Globalization](#) ↩
102. [Iranian Propaganda Video featuring John McCain, George Soros - YouTube](#) ↩
103. Mitchell, Lincoln A.. The Color Revolutions. United Kingdom: University of Pennsylvania Press, Incorporated, 2012. [SERBIAN STRIKERS, JOINED BY 20,000, FACE DOWN POLICE - The New York Times \(nytimes.com\)](#); [Memorandum of Conversation - President Vladimir Putin of Russia · Clinton Digital Library \(presidentiallibraries.us\)](#) ↩
104. Kuchma for instance sent troops to Iraq and wanted to join NATO, Saakashvili and Shevardnadze both wanted the same oil pipelines, and both wanted Russian peacekeepers out of South Ossetia. Which was the main conflict between Putin and the Georgians. (Zygar 2016, p. 104) [BBC Two - Putin, Russia and the West](#) Episode 2. ↩
105. McFaul, Michael. "Transitions from Postcommunism". Journal of Democracy 16, no. 3 (July 2005): 5-19. ↩
106. [Grants Program \(archive.org\)](#) ↩
107. Zygar 2016, p. 154 - 170 ↩
108. [O'Reilly Factor guest Richard Poe smeared George Soros; A Media Matters for America analysis of a NewsMax cover story | Media Matters for America](#) ↩ ↩
109. Horowitz, David., Poe, Richard. The Shadow Party: How George Soros, Hillary Clinton, and Sixties Radicals Seized Control of the Democratic Party. United States: HarperCollins Christian Publishing, 2006.p. 232-233 ↩
110. It's possible that Beck picked this up from the Alex Jones Show. As Beck was accused at this time by Jones of plagiarism. And there is certainly a pattern of coincidences between what Jones covered one day and what Beck covered the next. Jones, for his part, picked up the idea that Google, the CIA, and Soros were working together to overthrow the Egyptian government from Webster Tarpley, another former LaRouche writer who had spun off to form his own brand in the 90s. [Glenn Beck's Shtick? Alex Jones Got There First – RollingStone.com \(archive.org\)](#). [Watch - ALEX JONES Prison Planet TV \(infowars.com\)](#). ↩ ↩

111. In addition to these, Michael McFaul says he was personally accused by Putin of trying to overthrow the Russian government. [Michael McFaul on Vladimir Putin and Russia](#) ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩
112. Global Research itself seems to have already had a partnership with Russia before the Arab spring, but after the Arab Spring, Engdahl and Choussodovsky became regulars on Russia today and Engdahl was added to the masthead of several Kremlin backed Duginist think tanks.
https://www.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2020/08/Pillars-of-Russia's-Disinformation-and-Propaganda-Ecosystem_08-04-20.pdf ↩
113. Zygar 2016, p. 198-223 ↩
114. Ibid, Nikitina, Yulia. "The 'Color Revolutions' and 'Arab Spring' in Russian Official Discourse." Connections 14, no. 1 (2014): 87–104. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/26326387>. ↩
115. Snyder, Timothy. The Road to Unfreedom: Russia, Europe, America. United Kingdom: Crown, 2019. P.48-54 ↩
116. Ibid p.78-79 ↩
117. Zygar, Mikhail. War and Punishment: The Story of Russian Oppression and Ukrainian Resistance. United Kingdom: Orion, 2023. Ch.12 ↩
118. <https://www.nytimes.com/1993/08/26/world/russia-chastises-its-trade-minister.html>, nyder 2019, p 97-8 ↩
119. [Russia's Plan For Ukraine: Purported Leaked Strategy Document Raises Alarm \(rferl.org\)](#) This strategy document contains several ticks that regularly appear in Glazyev's writings ↩
120. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2014/jan/26/ukraine-president-concessions-protests-violence> ↩ ↩
121. The full phone call can be listened to here: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WV9J6sxCs5k>; It's worth noting one other myth about Victoria Nuland: namely that she "gave cookies to the protesters to encourage them". In reality she gave sandwiches to both protesters and police.
<https://www.rferl.org/a/25197233.html> ↩ ↩
122. <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/01/04/world/europe/ukraine-leader-was-defeated-even-before-he-was-ousted.htm> ↩
123. In the 6 weeks between the Russian army taking over Crimea, and Igor Girkin's takeover of Sloviansk, there were only 6 deaths attributable to political violence. [Timeline of the 2014 pro-Russian unrest in Ukraine - Wikipedia](#) ↩ ↩
124. [Russia and the "Color Revolution" \(csis.org\)](#), [Are 'Color Revolutions' A New Front In U.S.-Russia Tensions? : NPR](#) ↩
125. Some Examples: 1. [The Silence of American Hawks About Kiev's Atrocities | The Nation](#); 2. [It's not Russia that's pushed Ukraine to the brink of war | Seumas Milne | The Guardian](#); 3. [It's not Russia that's pushed Ukraine to the brink of war | Seumas Milne | The Guardian](#) ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩
126. This theory became popular with Jack Posobiec for instance: [\(2\) Jack Poso us on X: "BREAKING: 'They used George Floyd's death as a pretext to launch a domestic color revolution. Derek Chauvin was just a loose end to them' https://t.co/EC7UAMRvde" / X \(twitter.com\)](#) ↩ ↩
127. [In Cold War Echo, Obama Strategy Writes Off Putin - The New York Times \(nytimes.com\)](#) ↩
128. Zygar, 2023 Ch.14 ↩
129. Greene, Samuel A., Robertson, Graeme B.. Putin V. the People: The Perilous Politics of a Divided Russia. United Kingdom: Yale University Press, 2019. p. 228 ↩ ↩
130. Full Video here: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NcSmmd5g88Y> ↩ ↩ ↩
131. Most of the speeches from Rage Against the War Machine are here, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=duKeWROlp_Y&pp=ygUccmFnZSBhZ2FpbmN0IHRoZSB3YXlgbWFjaGluZQ%3D%3D ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩ ↩
132. The topic of the rise of Anti-intellectualism and Post-Truth Era, especially in U.S.A., I recommend checking out the [Professor Dave Explain](#) channel on YouTube ↩

133. https://archive.schillerinstitute.com/highlite/highlite_china_vis.html ↩
134. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Schiller_Institute#Political_activity ↩ ↩
135. <https://news.cgtn.com/news/2023-09-22/VHJhbnNjcmlwdDc0ODA3/index.html> ↩